

TRAVELOGUE



JOURNEYS. MOMENTS. MEMORIES.



V.T.R. RAVI KUMAR

Travelogue

V.T.R. Ravi Kumar



2026

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Dedication

For all kindred travelling spirits,
who know that the best journeys
are not measured in miles,
but in moments, memories, and stories
carried home.

Thirukkural

குறள் 397

யாதானும் நாடாமால் ஊராமால் என்னொருவன்
சாந்துணையும் கல்லாத வாறு.

Since every country is his own country,
and every town is his own town to a learned man,
why does a person remain uneducated until his death?

— திருவள்ளுவர் (Thiruvalluvar)

Contents

Prologue	1
Part I — Africa	2
Mauritius	3
Seychelles	7
Part II — Asia	11
Malaysia	12
Armenia	20
Azerbaijan	27
Georgia	32
Jordan	38
Singapore	43
Sri Lanka	50
Thailand	60
Part III — Europe	65
Switzerland	66
Italy	69
Portugal	75
Spain	79
United Kingdom	82
Part IV — North America	88
USA	89
Part V — Oceania	94
Australia	95
Part VI — India	101
Gujarat	102
Kashmir	107
Ladakh	114
Punjab	122
Rajasthan	128
Tamil Nadu	133

Uttar Pradesh 137

West Bengal 142

Epilogue 147

About the Author 148

Prologue

I have never been very good at saying no to travel.

Sometimes the reason was a birthday. Sometimes New Year. Sometimes a colleague sent an email asking if I wanted to join a trip. Sometimes a visa was easy to obtain. Sometimes the plan was simply to get into the car and see where the road went.

Looking back, there was no single philosophy behind all these journeys. I travelled because I was curious. I wanted to see places I had never seen, photograph them, understand how they felt, and sometimes simply get away from the familiar.

The photographs are important, but they are not the whole story. What stays with me are the decisions made along the way: sleeping in a Tata Sumo because an Army checkpoint stopped us, changing hotels because the first one was in the wrong place, buying a train ticket at the last moment, discovering a waterfall through sugarcane plantations, losing a tripod from an auto-rickshaw, or taking a flight because a road trip had become impossible.

Travel also taught me that uncertainty is not always something to eliminate. Sometimes it is the thing that makes a journey interesting.

These are some of those journeys.

Part I — Africa

Mauritius



Mauritius was another short escape from Dubai for Pragati and me. As with many of our trips from Dubai, the ease of entry was part of the attraction — Mauritius did not require a visa. We travelled from 12 to 14 July 2019, with only a couple of days to experience the island.

A first taste of business class

The journey itself had a small milestone for us. These were our first business-class tickets, both on the onward and return Emirates flights. Even though the flight was only around six hours, the Emirates hospitality and the experience of flying business class made us enjoy every bit of the journey.

On arrival at Mauritius airport, collecting the rental car was remarkably simple. There was nobody to hand over the car to us — the keys were available, the car was already fuelled, and the expectation was simply that we would return it with fuel filled. Having our own car made much more sense than trying to depend on taxis or ride-hailing in an island destination. It gave us the freedom to explore at our own pace.

A resort worth staying in

We had chosen the Outrigger Beach Resort & Spa Mauritius in Bel Ombre after reading reviews on Booking.com. It turned out to be one of the highlights of the trip.

The resort had spacious cottages arranged along the beachfront, with each cottage having its own beach space. We could enjoy the sea and the sunsets almost from the back door of our cottage. The resort was large, yet it never felt crowded, which gave it a wonderfully relaxed atmosphere.

There were several restaurants catering to different tastes, and the food was excellent. Among the many choices, we found exactly what we had been longing for — familiar Indian food, including South Indian favourites such as idli and dosa. Finding those familiar flavours in such a setting was an unexpected pleasure.

Unlike Seychelles, where we had spent most of our short visit driving around Mahé, Mauritius was deliberately more relaxed. We spent a good part of our time enjoying the resort and its surroundings rather than trying to see everything.

A little exploring

We did venture out to some of the island's better-known sights, including the Chamarel Seven Colored Earth Geopark, Chamarel Waterfall and Black River Gorges National Park. We also visited local markets and came across Indian temples, another reminder of the familiar connections that we had unexpectedly found in Seychelles as well.

We took a half-day boat trip on what I remember as a sailing boat or catamaran. It had a comfortable area to sit and enjoy the journey, and took us to an offshore island before returning us to Mauritius. I don't

remember the name of the boat or island, so there is no reason to invent one now.

There was a useful contrast between these outings and the resort itself. The island invited us to explore, but the short length of the trip meant that we were constantly choosing between seeing something new and simply enjoying where we were staying. We chose a little of both.

The waterfall we almost didn't find

One of the most memorable outings came from something much less touristy. While looking at nearby attractions on Google, we found a waterfall that appeared to be close by. We followed the directions and eventually found ourselves driving through sugarcane plantations.

At that point I was a little concerned — not just about whether we were going in the right direction, but also about the safety of ourselves and the rental car. We decided to take a leap of faith and continued.

It was worth it. The waterfall was neat and clean, and there was hardly anyone around. Apart from a local selling tender coconuts, we were the only people there. We could actually swim in the pool below the waterfall and enjoy what felt like a tourist attraction entirely to ourselves.

That experience stayed with me partly because of the contrast with India, where popular tourist places can be crowded almost everywhere. Here we had found a beautiful spot, almost by accident, and for a while it felt as though it belonged only to us.

Mauritius in hindsight

Mauritius reminded me in some ways of Seychelles — both are small island destinations where having a car gives you considerable freedom to explore. But Mauritius felt better developed in terms of

infrastructure without losing the scenic beauty that makes these islands special.

There was also a nice balance to the trip. The car gave us independence, the resort gave us a place to slow down, and the unplanned waterfall gave us the kind of story that no itinerary could have produced. Even with only a couple of days, the trip never felt like we were simply moving from one attraction to another.

If I had to choose one thing that represents this trip, though, it would not be one of the tourist attractions. It would be the Outrigger itself: the spacious cottage, the beach just outside, the sunsets, the excellent food and the feeling of being in a large resort that somehow never felt crowded.

It was only a short trip, and that was intentional. But looking back, I think we could have stayed a little longer — and simply enjoyed the resort and the beach a little more.

Seychelles



Two days on Mahé

Seychelles was a short, spontaneous escape from Dubai. The ease of travelling there without a visa made the decision simple, and Pragati and I decided to make the most of a very short break.

We had only two days.

Instead of treating that as a reason to stay in one place, we did almost the opposite. We rented a car and spent most of the visit driving around Mahé, stopping whenever something caught our attention.

In hindsight, that probably tells you more about how we travelled at the time than any itinerary could.

Landing and getting on the road

We flew from Dubai on Emirates EK705, arriving early in the morning on 10 September 2016. At the airport we picked up a Suzuki Vitara rental from Absolute Cars and, with Google Maps as our guide, set off for the hotel.

The Crown Beach Hotel at Pointe au Sel was right beside the sea and had its own private beach. It was the kind of place where we could easily have spent the entire weekend doing nothing.

We didn't.

After reaching the hotel, we quickly set off to explore the island.

Around Mahé

Most of our time was spent on the road.

We visited Anse Royale Beach, Police Bay, Kempinski Beach and Bel Ombre. We also explored Victoria, including the Victoria Botanical Garden and the Sir Selwyn Selwyn-Clarke Market.

We drove up towards the Tea Tavern, where the tea factory and surrounding plantation offered a completely different side of the island. The occasional drizzle and cooler conditions made driving through the hills particularly pleasant.

Mahé is small enough that a car gives you a surprising amount of freedom. In a short period we were able to move from beaches to the capital, from markets to the hills and from developed areas into quieter stretches of the island.

The driving itself became part of the holiday.

A familiar sight far from home

One of the things that surprised us most was discovering how strong the Indian connection was in Seychelles.

There were many families of South Indian origin whose roots in the islands went back several generations. We came across Indian businesses and familiar cultural references in places where we had not expected to find them.

Then we found the Arul Migu Navashakti Vinayagar Temple.

Seeing a South Indian temple, complete with the deity and priest, so far from home was an unexpectedly comforting moment. Travel often makes you notice things about home that you normally take for granted, and this was one of those moments.

We had travelled to Seychelles looking for an island experience. Instead, we also found a small reminder of home.

Two very different sides of the trip

There was a funny contradiction in the way we travelled around Mahé.

We had chosen a hotel beside the sea with a private beach, but we hardly stayed there. The island kept tempting us to get back into the car and see what was around the next corner.

The weather helped. The occasional drizzle made the drives enjoyable rather than uncomfortable, and every new stretch of road seemed to offer another view or another place worth stopping for.

But two days is still only two days.

By the time we left, we had covered a surprising amount of Mahé, but we had also realised how much we had missed.

What we didn't do

We never really slowed down enough to enjoy the resort properly.

We could have spent more time on the private beach, simply walked around the property or tried activities such as snorkelling. Instead, we were almost always somewhere on the road.

That is probably my biggest memory of Seychelles: we came for an island escape, but spent most of our time exploring it from behind the wheel.

SEYCHELLES

I don't regret it. The driving gave us the chance to see much more of Mahé than we otherwise would have in such a short visit.

But if we ever return, I would do it differently.

I would keep the car, but I would also deliberately leave a day with no destination at all.

Looking back

Seychelles was only a two-day trip, but it became memorable because it combined several things we enjoyed about travel: an easy decision from Dubai, the freedom of a rental car, discovering places without a rigid itinerary and the occasional surprise of finding something familiar in a foreign country.

We saw beaches, hills, markets, gardens and tea plantations. We drove across Mahé, found a South Indian temple thousands of kilometres from home and returned to a beautiful hotel beside the sea that we barely had time to enjoy.

Perhaps that is the real lesson of this trip.

Sometimes a short trip is enough to discover a place.

It just isn't always enough to slow down and enjoy it.

Part II — Asia

Malaysia



May 16–23, 2023

Malaysia came into our travels at an interesting point. We had already travelled together to Thailand, and a couple of months earlier Singapore had turned an office trip into a holiday. Kuala Lumpur felt like a natural continuation of that rhythm — another work trip converted into personal travel, but this time Pragati and I travelled together from the very beginning.

The trip was meant to be a five-day visit to one of our office branches, where I had to spend time interacting with the team working under me. That meant the weekdays would inevitably revolve around work. But having Pragati with me changed what happened around those working hours. She would stay back during the day while I went to the office, and I would walk back to the hotel to take her out for lunch before returning to work. In the evenings, we would go out and see one thing at a time.

By the weekend, the rhythm changed completely. Saturday and Sunday were ours, and we could finally spend an entire day travelling instead of trying to fit a landmark into the few hours after work.

KL Sentral

We arrived in Kuala Lumpur in the evening on May 16. From the airport we took the train to KL Sentral, which turned out to be one of the best decisions of the trip without really being a decision at all. We were staying at Aloft Kuala Lumpur Sentral, right beside — almost above — the station.

The only problem was finding the entrance.

The hotel was so closely integrated with the station that getting to it involved a little asking around before we figured out that the entrance was actually accessible from inside the station itself. Once we found it, the location made perfect sense. My office was barely a three-minute walk away, and the railway connections meant that getting around Kuala Lumpur was remarkably convenient.

We had stayed at an Aloft in Delhi before, so the environment felt familiar. The Kuala Lumpur property had the same general feel, but it seemed cleaner and more polished to us. After checking in, though, we did not attempt any sightseeing. It was already evening, and the sensible thing was to find somewhere nearby for dinner and rest.

The next day the working holiday properly began.

One attraction at a time

The first few days were governed by the limitations of office life. There was no elaborate sightseeing plan. There was simply one attraction after another, fitted into the evening after work.

On May 17, we went to see the Petronas Twin Towers from outside. They are the sort of landmark that does not need much introduction. Seeing them in person, standing there beneath their unmistakable shape, was enough. But we would return to the towers later in the trip for a completely different experience.

The following evening took us to Central Market. It gave us a different side of Kuala Lumpur from the monumental towers — a place to wander, browse and take in the atmosphere without having to make the evening into a major expedition.

May 19 was for Bukit Bintang. This was where sightseeing and shopping naturally merged. The shops were impressive and seemed to have something for everyone. I remember looking at the electronics and thinking that I could probably live there indefinitely. Food and water would have been optional; the electronics section was enough.

Pragati found herself a nice leather handbag. I came away with a GoPro Hero 11, along with the usual collection of other shopping and souvenirs. It was one of those evenings where the attraction was not a single monument but the experience of being in a part of the city where there always seemed to be something to look at or buy.

But the most important discovery of those first few days was not a landmark at all.

The search for food

Food is always one of the practical questions that comes with international travel for us. Vegetarian food is not necessarily difficult everywhere, but finding food that feels familiar is another matter entirely.

As we usually do, I searched for Indian restaurants and found a Saravana Bhavan nearby. It sounded like the safe option. Unfortunately, the food was not up to the mark.

And then, almost by accident, we discovered **Mr Naan & Mrs Idli**.

That accidental discovery solved our food problem for the rest of the stay.

What made the place special was that we could get the kind of food we were comfortable with — including tawa phulka and typical North Indian food. For Pragati in particular, that was a welcome relief. Instead of wondering where our next vegetarian meal would come from, we had found a place we could simply return to.

And return we did.

It became our lunch-and-dinner place throughout our time in Kuala Lumpur. There is something comforting about finding a small piece of familiar food in an unfamiliar city, especially when you are travelling for work and the days already have enough uncertainty in them.

The meal also had a fitting ending: hot gulab jamun. A steaming gulab jamun after dinner became almost a ritual, and it was the perfect way to finish the day.

Sometimes a travel memory is not the famous attraction you came to see. Sometimes it is the restaurant you stumbled upon and then refused to leave.

Saturday: Batu Caves and Menara KL

Saturday, May 20, was different. There was no office waiting for me, so for the first time during the trip we had an entire day to ourselves.

We used the train again, this time to go to Batu Caves. Staying at KL Sentral made the journey particularly easy, and the fact that we could simply use the train was one of the things we appreciated about where we were staying.

It was our first visit to Batu Caves.

There is always a certain pride in seeing Indian temples outside India. Usually, however, there is also a familiar feeling that the temple somehow becomes a smaller version of what we know back home. Batu Caves was very different. It was huge.

The giant Murugan statue immediately establishes the scale of the place, while the colourful staircase leading upwards becomes an attraction in itself. The climb is tiring – especially when you are determined to go all the way up – but neither of us would have considered stopping halfway. Once we reached the top, the views and the cave itself made the effort worthwhile.

Inside the cave, the scale and atmosphere were mesmerizing. And there was another small detail that made the experience unexpectedly familiar. We could see many South Indians, particularly Tamils, visiting the temple. In a place thousands of kilometres away from home, hearing and seeing people from a culture so familiar created a strange but comforting feeling.

For a moment, it did not feel quite so far from home.

From Batu Caves we continued with the day's sightseeing and visited Menara Kuala Lumpur.

Menara KL offered a completely different perspective on the city. The glass-floor experience at the Sky Terrace was something we did not want to miss. It was a paid attraction and there were long lines, but the wait was worth it. Standing on the glass and looking down while taking photographs gives you that peculiar mixture of excitement and nervousness that these experiences are designed to create.

And then there was the view.

One of the best things about Menara KL is that you can look across the city and see the Petronas Towers themselves. The towers are spectacular from the ground, but seeing them from Menara KL gives you an entirely different appreciation of them. It is almost as though the landmark becomes part of the cityscape rather than simply being the cityscape.

Sunday: Inside the Petronas Towers

Sunday, May 21, was our second full day without office commitments, and we had deliberately kept the Petronas Towers interior visit for this part of the trip.

A few days earlier we had stood outside them. Now we were going inside.

We went up to the viewing level and experienced the city from the towers, including the famous glass bridge between the two buildings. There is something about going up a landmark like this that is difficult to separate from the experience of other great towers around the world.

For me, the feeling was almost the same as going up the Burj Khalifa to the 127th floor.

Same same, but different.

The cities are different, the buildings are different, and the views have their own character, but the feeling of looking at an enormous city from high above has something universal about it.

It also completed our Petronas experience nicely. We had first seen the towers from outside on a weekday evening, then seen them again from Menara KL, and finally stood inside them and looked out over Kuala Lumpur. The same landmark had given us three different perspectives.

Back to work

The weekend was over, but the trip was not.

May 22 and 23 were working days again. There was no need to squeeze another major attraction into those days. After work, we mostly relaxed at the hotel, visited local shops and returned to our now-familiar food routine at Mr Naan & Mrs Idli.

In a way, those quieter evenings belonged to the same trip as the towers and Batu Caves. Travel does not have to mean constantly

moving from one attraction to another. Sometimes the nicest part is having a place where you know what dinner will be, knowing that the hotel is just a short walk from the office, and having someone with you who is sharing the whole experience.

That was what made Kuala Lumpur different from Singapore.

Singapore had started as my work trip, with Pragati joining me only after the office portion had already begun. Malaysia was shared from day one. I went to work in the mornings, came back for lunch, returned to work, and then we went out together in the evenings. When the weekend arrived, the workday restrictions disappeared and the trip opened up into full-day exploration.

The city itself made that transition unusually easy. KL Sentral kept us connected, the office was almost next door, the trains took us to places like Batu Caves, and our accidental discovery of Mr Naan & Mrs Idli meant that even food — something that can sometimes complicate international travel for us — became effortless.

On May 23, we flew back to Chennai.

Kuala Lumpur stayed with me not because it was an uninterrupted holiday. It was almost the opposite. It was a trip where work and travel were woven together so naturally that neither seemed to get in the way of the other.

There were the big memories: the Petronas Towers, Menara KL, Batu Caves and the view from above. There was the shopping, the GoPro, Pragati's handbag and the electronics stores that I could happily have spent far too much time exploring.

But there was also the everyday rhythm — the short walk to the office, the train rides from KL Sentral, meeting Pragati for lunch, evening sightseeing, and ending the day with hot gulab jamun.

TRAVELOGUE

Perhaps that is why Kuala Lumpur feels less like a sightseeing checklist and more like a lived-in travel memory.

Armenia



We went to Armenia twice, both times in the middle of winter. The first trip was in November–December 2017; the second came around the New Year of 2020. Both times we travelled together.

What started as an easy destination to reach from the UAE became a place we genuinely enjoyed returning to. The two journeys also gave us a chance to see Armenia in winter, when its mountains, lakes and towns take on a completely different character.

Why Armenia

The original attraction was simple: while I was living in the UAE, an Indian passport holder with a valid UAE residence permit could enter Armenia visa-free. It was remarkably easy to book a flight and go. That ease was enough to make Armenia an obvious choice — and, two years later, an obvious place to return to.

But the practical reason for choosing Armenia quickly became secondary to the experience itself. We discovered a country with an ancient Christian heritage, dramatic landscapes, mountain resorts and, most unexpectedly for us, a surprisingly strong connection with India.

Yerevan

Yerevan became our base on both visits. We stayed at the Marriott near Republic Square, which was an excellent location for exploring the centre on foot and returning easily after a day out in the cold.

Republic Square is one of the defining spaces of the Armenian capital, surrounded by some of Yerevan's most important civic buildings. For us, though, it also became the place where many of the small encounters of the trip happened — walking around, browsing shops and meeting people.

There was another unexpected connection with India. Yerevan had many Indian students, particularly students studying medicine. On one occasion an Indian student staying at the hotel helped us bargain in a local shop because he could speak Armenian. It was one of those small travel moments that makes a foreign place feel a little less foreign.

The warmth of the Armenian people was probably what stayed with me most. Even in the cold of winter, people were remarkably welcoming. Around Republic Square, shopkeepers who discovered that we were Indian often became especially warm and friendly. There seemed to be a genuine affection for Indians, perhaps helped by their familiarity with Bollywood.

Lake Sevan

Lake Sevan was one of the places that made Armenia feel much larger than the map suggested.

It is one of the world's high-altitude freshwater lakes and Armenia's largest lake. In winter, the landscape around it becomes especially stark: water, mountains, open sky and cold air creating a sense of enormous space.

ARMENIA

For us, Sevan was less about doing a particular activity and more about experiencing that landscape. After the bustle of Yerevan, standing beside the lake felt quiet and expansive.

It also helped explain why Armenia works so well as a winter destination. The country can move very quickly from an urban setting into mountain and lake landscapes that feel remote.

Garni and Geghard

Garni Temple and Geghard Monastery gave us two very different glimpses into Armenia's long religious and cultural history.

Garni is particularly unusual because it is a surviving classical pagan temple in a country whose identity is so strongly associated with Christianity. Its setting above the Azat River gorge makes the visit about the landscape as much as the structure itself.

Geghard, by contrast, is a medieval Christian monastery complex partly carved into the surrounding rock. The combination of stone architecture and the natural gorge around it gives the place a very different atmosphere from Garni.

Visiting both on the same journey made the history easier to appreciate. Armenia's past isn't represented by one period or one style; it is layered across centuries.

Tsitsernakaberd

Tsitsernakaberd, the Armenian Genocide Memorial Complex, was a very different experience.

The memorial commemorates the victims of the Armenian Genocide, and the visit is difficult to approach simply as sightseeing. The starkness of the memorial and the silence around it create an atmosphere that stays with you.

It was deeply sad and sobering. Travel sometimes introduces you to beauty; sometimes it confronts you with history that is difficult to absorb. Tsitsernakaberd was very much the latter.

Tsaghkadzor — our first ski-resort experience

Tsaghkadzor became one of the happiest memories of our winter trips.

The mountain resort sits on the slopes of Mount Teghenis and is one of Armenia's main winter tourism centres. We did not stay there, but took the ropeway up to experience the snow and the views.

For me, this was significant because I had always wanted to experience a proper ski resort. I had not managed to do that elsewhere, and Armenia unexpectedly gave me my first taste of it.

We weren't serious skiers. We were tourists enjoying the cable car, the snow, the mountain scenery and the atmosphere of a winter resort. Sometimes a first experience does not need to be elaborate to become memorable.

Jermuk

Jermuk was another place that stood out.

Located high in the mountains of southern Armenia, Jermuk is known for its mineral springs and its role as a spa and health resort. The town sits amid forests and mountains, with the Arpa River gorge cutting through the landscape.

We saw the frozen waterfall, which looked particularly striking in winter. We also experienced the local mineral water, something that is deeply associated with Jermuk and has been used there for generations.

What I liked about Jermuk was that it felt less like a conventional sightseeing stop. The landscape, the water and the town's identity as a mountain resort were all part of the experience.

Khor Virap, Areni and the Armenian landscape

We also visited Khor Virap, Areni Winery, Kecharis Monastery and the Haghartsin Monastic Complex.

Khor Virap is one of Armenia's most recognisable monastery settings, with Mount Ararat forming the dramatic backdrop when visibility is good. The location makes it easy to understand why Armenian religious sites are so closely associated with the surrounding landscape.

Areni took us in a completely different direction. Wine is an important part of Armenian culture, and visiting a winery made the experience more tangible than simply seeing bottles in a shop. Armenian wine became one of the small pleasures we carried through both trips.

Kecharis and Haghartsin added yet more layers to the journey – medieval monasteries set in mountain environments, where the journey to the site is almost as memorable as the building itself.

Food

Being vegetarian made food one of the practical challenges. We managed with pizzas, salads and breads, but food was not one of the easiest parts of travelling for us.

It was never enough to spoil the journey. We had become quite good at adapting, finding something suitable and moving on. Travel has a way of teaching you that not every meal has to be perfect for the trip to be good.

What I would tell a first-time visitor

The people are kind. Do nothing to lose their trust.

Make time for Lake Sevan and Jermuk. Take time to explore local places rather than limiting yourself to the obvious sights. The flea markets are worth wandering through, particularly for handmade products. I remember handcrafted wooden chess boards in particular — the kind of thing that carries a little piece of the place home with you.

And leave some room for Armenian wine. A visit to Armenia should include some.

If travelling in winter, the mountain resorts are worth experiencing even if you are not a serious skier. For us, simply riding the ropeway at Tsaghkadzor and seeing the mountains covered in snow was enough.

Armenia and Chennai

Armenia also changed how I looked at a part of home. Chennai has an Armenian connection, including Armenian Street. After visiting Armenia and seeing something of the country's culture and history for myself, that connection became much more tangible to me.

It was one of those small discoveries that travel gives you unexpectedly: you leave home thinking you are going somewhere completely foreign, only to discover that the destination has left traces back home as well.

Looking back

Armenia was never a destination we had spent years dreaming about. The first trip happened largely because getting there was easy. Yet it became one of the countries we liked enough to return to.

ARMENIA

The two winter journeys gave us Yerevan, Lake Sevan, ancient temples and monasteries, the sombre history of Tsitsernakaberd, the snow at Tsaghkadzor, the frozen waterfall at Jermuk, Armenian wine and, perhaps most importantly, many small interactions with people who made the country feel welcoming.

Sometimes the best destinations are the ones you choose for a practical reason and then discover for a completely different one.

Azerbaijan



Some trips begin with a grand plan. Others begin with a practical reason to go somewhere. Azerbaijan was a little of both for us.

Visa was relatively easy to obtain, and the dates happened to coincide with my birthday. That was enough reason for Pragati and me to decide to spend a few days in Azerbaijan.

We flew from Dubai to Baku on Azerbaijan Airlines on 16 March 2018. I had booked a car to take us from Baku airport to Shahdag, where we were going to stay at a ski resort. Pragati had almost no idea what this trip was going to be like. My own knowledge was mostly limited to what I had read in online reviews.

The car was waiting for us at the airport with a placard carrying our name. The drive to Shahdag was quite long. For a while, I began to wonder if I had made a mistake.

We had booked a ski resort, but where were the mountains?

The landscape along most of the journey wasn't particularly impressive. Pragati had fallen asleep, which was probably fortunate

because I was already imagining her disappointment if we reached a ski resort and found no snow.

Then, during the last few kilometres, everything changed.

The landscape suddenly became white. Snow appeared everywhere and the mountains finally came into view. I woke Pragati with a sigh of relief.

We had reached Shahdag.

A ski resort in the mountains

We checked into the Pik Palace, Shahdag, Autograph Collection around noon, and the hotel immediately made an impression on us. The rooms were enormous and the whole place had the kind of polished, luxurious feel that reminded me of something from a James Bond movie.

Our room overlooked a completely snow-covered mountain slope where people skied. The hotel itself sat partway up the resort, with cable cars going both up and down. Because normal visitors couldn't simply come up to this part of the resort, it was relatively quiet, with only a small number of ski enthusiasts around.

That suited me perfectly.

It wasn't snowing when we arrived, so after settling in and taking some much-needed rest following the flight and long drive, we dressed comfortably and took the cable car down. The lower part of the resort was much busier, with buses bringing tourists in to enjoy the snow and mountain scenery.

We spent some time there, snacking and enjoying the views, before returning to the hotel for the night.

Then, sometime in the middle of the night, Pragati woke me up rather vigorously.

For a moment I wondered what had happened.

The news was good.

It was snowing.

I looked outside and the view was mesmerising. Snow was falling over the resort, while snowploughs were already working through the night to keep the ski slopes clear.

This was our first stay at a ski resort. I had wanted to experience one during our Armenia trip but hadn't been able to. Now, unexpectedly, I was doing it in Azerbaijan.

The resort was beautifully scenic and, compared with the crowded ski resorts I had seen in Switzerland, felt wonderfully quiet. I later realised that we were only about 30 kilometres from the Russian border.

For the next couple of days, there wasn't any great agenda. We rode the cable cars up and down, enjoyed the mountain views and simply experienced being in a ski resort. For hotel guests, the cable-car rides were included, so we could ride them as many times as we wanted.

That was exactly the kind of holiday I enjoy.

I don't remember doing anything elaborate for my birthday, and honestly, I don't think I needed to. I have always liked being away from home on important days such as birthdays or New Year. Being somewhere different is celebration enough for me.

Back to Baku

Our flight home was from Baku, and Shahdag was far enough away that we decided not to take a chance with the return journey. We checked out on 18 March and headed back towards Baku.

I hadn't even booked our Baku hotel in advance. I booked it while we were on the road.

AZERBAIJAN

We stayed at the Hilton Baku, in a high-floor room almost at the top of the hotel. The view from the room was beautiful, looking towards the Caspian Sea.

Baku was a complete change from Shahdag. We explored the city, visited a local market, ate whatever vegetarian food we could find, and bought some nice winter jackets.

And then there was the Caspian Sea.

I had already seen the Dead Sea during our Jordan trip, and now I was standing beside another sea that felt quite different. There was one similarity, though – the smell. The Caspian Sea, at least where we experienced it, had a noticeable crude-oil smell, which made me smile.

It was still wonderful to see it.

A couple of strange moments

One evening, while walking in a park near the Caspian Sea, we noticed a tall gentleman in an army uniform accompanied by a bodyguard. He had an imposing personality, and we thought we might ask him for a photograph.

We did ask.

He politely refused.

Only later did we realise that he was apparently a fairly senior military figure. In hindsight, the polite refusal was probably the best possible outcome.

There was another incident in the local market that was less amusing.

I had a feeling that someone was following us. I noticed a man behind us for quite some time and told Pragati. Rather than continuing to walk, we decided to sit down and see what happened.

The man eventually passed us, and for a moment we felt relieved. But after crossing us, he spoke to another man, who then appeared to follow us afterwards.

I still don't know what was really happening. Perhaps it was my overprotective side imagining something that wasn't there. Perhaps there really was something unusual going on.

Either way, we decided not to take chances. We left the area quickly and returned to our hotel.

A birthday in the snow

Looking back, Azerbaijan was an unusual birthday trip.

There wasn't a grand birthday celebration, no carefully planned itinerary and very little that was fixed in advance. There was a long drive from Baku wondering whether we had made the right choice, followed by the sudden appearance of snow and mountains. There was a beautiful ski resort, cable-car rides, a surprise snowfall in the middle of the night, and finally a high-rise hotel overlooking the Caspian Sea.

The trip had started because Azerbaijan was relatively easy for us to visit.

It ended up giving us our first experience of staying at a ski resort — something I had wanted to do for a long time.

Sometimes that's all you need from a birthday.

Just be somewhere else.

Georgia



Georgia was special to us for a very simple reason: it was the destination that made our first personal international trip possible. From Dubai, the fact that Georgia offered visa on arrival made the decision easy. Pragati and I travelled there from 26 November to 1 December 2015, not knowing that the short trip would leave us with so many memories — some sweet, some sour, and some completely unexpected.

Our first international trip

We flew from Dubai to Tbilisi on Flydubai FZ711 on 26 November 2015. The landing itself was something we remember. As the aircraft touched down, fellow passengers started clapping and cheering. It was new to us — almost as if a successful landing was something worth celebrating.

The welcome at immigration, however, was very different. The border police were extremely rude and the immigration check felt unnecessarily intrusive. It was an unpleasant first impression.

Fortunately, that was not representative of the people we met during the rest of our journey.

Georgians were, by contrast, remarkably warm and friendly. There seemed to be a particular affection for Indians. We discovered that the old Soviet connection had left many people familiar with Indian cinema, especially the films of Raj Kapoor. Some people could sing songs from *Mera Naam Joker* and other old Hindi films with surprising fluency. It was an unexpected cultural connection, and one of the things that made the trip memorable.

Tbilisi and a hotel change

Our first hotel in Tbilisi was B&B Old Tbilisi, which we had booked through Booking.com. The address was on Kardenakhi Street, well away from the central areas we wanted to explore. As soon as we checked in, we regretted the choice.

I went out for a short walk and noticed a much nicer-looking hotel nearby. I walked in and asked the manager if they had rooms available. They did. We decided to abandon the Booking.com reservation and moved into Mirobelle instead.

It turned out to be an excellent decision. The hotel was right next to the Holy Trinity Church, and we could actually see the church from our room window. There was another small kindness that reminded us of an experience we had earlier in Leh: Mirobelle allowed us to leave our luggage there without charging us for it.

The Holy Trinity Church became one of our first impressions of Tbilisi, and the city itself soon opened up to us through a mixture of walking, sightseeing and spontaneous decisions.

An unexpected train journey to Batumi

One of the best parts of the trip happened almost by accident.

We decided to travel to Batumi by train. It was an impromptu decision, and rather than taking the simplest available option, we bought business-class tickets. The seats were comfortable and, to our surprise, the train had good internet connectivity.

Pragati was into watching the television series *Chanakya* at the time, and she managed to watch several episodes during the journey using the train's internet connection.

At the station, just before boarding, we met another Indian couple from Abu Dhabi. We became friendly with them and decided to explore Batumi together.

There was one small problem: we had no hotel booking in Batumi and would be arriving at night. It was a risky decision. Thankfully, the couple were already staying at a hotel, so we checked there as well and managed to get a walk-in room.

We then hired a cab and explored the surrounding area together.

Batumi and the Black Sea

Batumi gave us a very different side of Georgia. We visited the Black Sea, saw Batumi from the viewpoint and drove towards the Sarpi border with Turkey.

We also visited the Gonio-Apsaros Archaeological Museum and travelled into the countryside to see Makhuntseti Waterfall and the old stone arch bridge nearby. The landscape, the roads and the small settlements along the way made the drive itself part of the experience.

We also visited the Adjarian Wine House. Georgian wine became one of the recurring themes of the trip, and we would later buy some to take back to Dubai.

The two days in Batumi were short, but they were packed with places, people and the feeling of having discovered much more than we had planned.

Standing beside the Black Sea was also a small milestone in its own right. Until then, seas were mostly something I knew through maps, photographs and names. Being there made the geography of the world feel much more real.

Back to Tbilisi

After returning to Tbilisi, we continued exploring the city. We took the Rustaveli–Mtatsminda Cable Car and went all the way to the top.

There was another completely unexpected moment waiting for us there. We found an Indian tea and coffee seller at the top. We had a different kind of coffee there – with rum – and it became one of those little travel memories that stays with you precisely because you never expected it.

We also booked a City Sightseeing bus tour. It turned out to be a wonderful way to see more of the country and, just as importantly, meet other travellers. We became friendly with some of the people on the tour and stayed in touch with them long after we returned to Dubai, sharing photographs through Facebook.

The trip also took us beyond Tbilisi to Tsminda Nino's Monastery, the Bodbe Monastery Complex and Kvareli. In Kvareli, we visited Corporation Kindzmarauli and took part in a wine tasting.

Georgia was clearly proud of its wine tradition, and we enjoyed experiencing it rather than simply buying a bottle from a shop. We bought Georgian wine to take back with us – and it did not last very long after we returned to Dubai.

Food, language and small discoveries

GEORGIA

Food was, as usual, one of the minor challenges for us as vegetarians. We managed, as we always did, by finding what we could. Freshly baked breads and cheese were abundant, and we also noticed how plentiful pomegranates were.

Language was a bigger challenge. Many of the local people we met spoke Georgian or Russian, while English was not widely spoken. Somehow, we managed. A combination of the few English words we could find, gestures and what effectively became sign language got us through.

And perhaps that was part of the fun. We were not travelling with the expectation that everything would be easy or familiar. We were figuring things out as we went along.

We also experienced a traditional Georgian sulphur bath in Tbilisi before the trip came to an end.

Looking back

When we left Georgia on Flydubai FZ712 on 1 December, we were carrying much more than the photographs and bottles of wine we had collected.

This was our **first personal international trip**. We had travelled because getting to Georgia was relatively straightforward, but the country gave us far more than an easy visa arrangement.

There was the uncomfortable beginning at immigration, followed by the warmth of ordinary Georgians. There was the spontaneous train journey to Batumi, the Indian couple from Abu Dhabi, the unexpected hotel booking, the Black Sea, waterfalls, monasteries and wine country. There was the Indian coffee seller on top of the cable-car ride, the friends we made on the sightseeing bus, and the strange but wonderful discovery that people thousands of kilometres away could still remember and sing old Raj Kapoor songs.

TRAVELOGUE

More than anything, Georgia opened a door. Before this trip, international travel had been something we imagined and discussed. After it, it became something we knew we could actually do.

It was a short trip, but it opened a door for us.

Georgia was the beginning of our personal international travels — and perhaps that is why, even after all these years, the memories still feel so fresh.

Jordan



A solo trip into the unknown

Jordan was the only country on this long-running travel list that I visited alone.

Pragati had to travel to India, and I decided to use that window to visit a place she would probably not choose. I had always wanted to see the Dead Sea, after seeing photographs of people floating in it, and Petra was another strong reason to make the trip.

I travelled from Dubai to Amman from 30 November to 5 December 2019. I stayed in Amman for a day before taking a bus to Wadi Musa.

Travelling alone

Travelling alone meant freedom. I could decide where to stay, how to travel and how much to plan. I discovered that a little uncertainty could actually make a trip more enjoyable.

For the first time in my life I stayed in a hostel. The Nomad in Wadi Musa had rooms with bunker beds and travellers from different countries. Everyone was welcoming and made me comfortable.

It was also a learning experience. Unlike a hotel, I discovered that I had to carry my own towel and that many things I would normally expect to be included were paid for separately. It was less polished than a hotel, but the people and the experience made up for it.

I had not even planned where I would stay in Wadi Musa. On the bus from Amman, I met a fellow traveller who was heading to a hostel. He suggested I try my luck there. Fortunately, I got a bed.

That became one of the pleasures of travelling alone: I did not have to know exactly what would happen next.

Petra

Petra was the place I had most wanted to see, and it was even better than the photographs suggested.

The journey through the narrow gorges before they suddenly open into the massive monuments is something photographs cannot really prepare you for. Everyone around me seemed to have the same reaction — surprise at what was suddenly in front of us.

There was one problem. I had made the mistake of wearing a new leather boot for the first time on this trip. It had bitten my foot badly, and Petra involved a lot of walking from the entrance to the Treasury and then further into the site.

There were horse carts, mainly useful for elderly visitors, and after the Treasury it was possible to hire a mule. With my foot hurting badly, I eventually did that.

But the walking had one unexpected benefit. I found a small ledge that a few people were climbing towards, and it led to a beautiful view of the Treasury. A man was serving tea at the top. I made the climb and took some photographs. The climb was tough, but there was almost

nobody up there, which meant I could photograph the Treasury without the usual crowd getting into the frame.

Petra was so impressive that I visited it again later in the trip, this time wearing comfortable footwear and enjoying it with much less pain.

The two visits gave me two very different experiences of the same place. The first was about surprise and pushing through discomfort; the second was about slowing down enough to actually enjoy it. For a photographer, Petra also had something else: scale. The monuments are impressive, but the approach through the gorge makes the reveal feel even more dramatic.

Wadi Rum

After Petra, my new friend from Taiwan and I planned the next part of the journey. This time we made some calls and booked a stay inside Wadi Rum.

After the bus ride, someone was waiting to take us into the desert camp. The camp was a collection of tents arranged in a traditional nomadic style, sitting in the shadow of huge sand mountains.

Food was prepared traditionally too, with the ingredients placed in containers and cooked slowly in a pit of hot coals. There were travellers from Greece, England and many other places. Before long, the camp had become a small international group of friends.

The next morning we took a 4x4 ride into Wadi Rum. We saw the famous arch, the place associated with *Lawrence of Arabia*, and several other parts of the desert.

The night was something else. We decided to use the low light and photograph star trails. Setting up a tripod in complete darkness was a challenge, but we managed it. That night, in the middle of the desert, was one of the memorable moments of the trip.

The Dead Sea

On the last day, I had to get back to Amman for my evening flight. Rather than simply take the route I had used coming south, I asked my driver to take me back via the Dead Sea.

There are two major routes between Wadi Musa and Amman. I had come by the King's Highway; for the return I chose the route through the Dead Sea.

I stopped where there were other tourists, changed into my swimwear and covered myself in the famous black mud. Then I got into the Dead Sea.

Everything people say about floating is true — you really do float. The water itself tasted like crude oil, but that hardly mattered. I had finally done the thing that had originally made me want to come to Jordan.

From the Dead Sea I continued towards Amman, stopping at Mount Nebo for a short break. The view across the vast stretch of land towards Jordan and Israel was a fitting final scene before heading to the airport.

Looking back

If Pragati had been with me, I would probably have travelled differently. I would have been more protective, looked for more expensive and comfortable accommodation, and food would have required more planning because she is less accommodating than I am when it comes to travel conditions.

Travelling alone allowed me to stay in a hostel, take buses, change plans, walk more, accept uncertainty and push myself further than I normally would.

That is what Jordan gave me beyond Petra and the Dead Sea: the realization that uncertainty can be part of the fun of travel.

JORDAN

It also gave me something I had not expected when I left Dubai: the confidence that I could enjoy a journey entirely on my own terms. There was no one else to consult about the next bus, the next hostel or whether to take one more photograph. Every decision was mine.

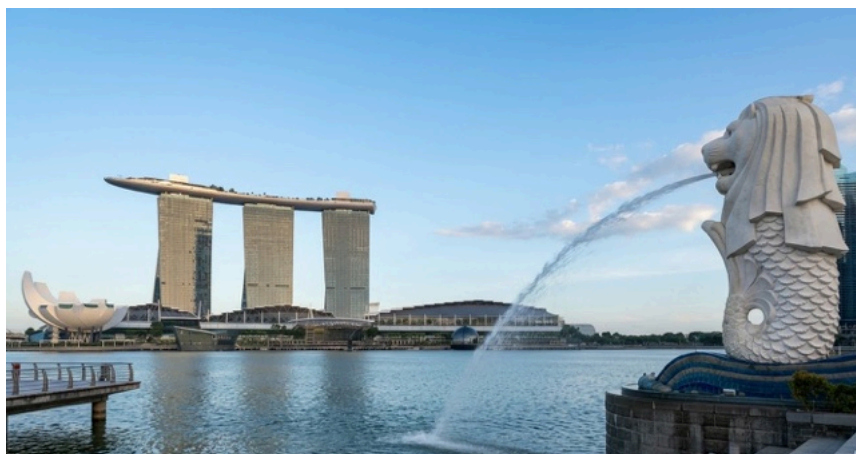
I came back from Jordan with a very good feeling about having travelled alone. I would do it again anytime.

If you are visiting Jordan

My advice would be simple:

- Leave some room for uncertainty. Not everything needs to be planned.
- Give Petra enough time — and wear comfortable shoes.
- Experience Wadi Rum overnight if you can.
- Do the Dead Sea rather than just looking at photographs of it.
- Talk to fellow travellers. Some of the best parts of my trip happened because I did not know what was going to happen next.

Singapore



The work trip that became our holiday

Singapore had been on my travel list for a long time, but somehow it took until 2023 for me to finally get there.

The opportunity came through work. I had an office trip to Singapore in March 2023, and for the first few days it was exactly that — a work trip. I flew from Chennai on 6 March and spent the first three days focused on the official part of the visit.

But I had a plan for what would happen after that.

Pragati would come to Singapore on 9 March.

That changed the character of the trip completely. What had started as another office journey became a small holiday for the two of us. I had already begun discovering Singapore on my own, but from the moment I went to Changi Airport to receive Pragati, the city felt different.

SINGAPORE

Before heading to the hotel, we stopped at Jewel Changi Airport. Changi itself is one of those places that has become a landmark, and Jewel adds another dimension to the airport experience. It was a fitting introduction to a city that seemed to combine infrastructure, design and everyday convenience unusually well.

Singapore would eventually become a frequent destination for me because of work. But this particular visit remained special because it was the first time I experienced it as a place of travel with Pragati.

Seeing Singapore from above

One of the things we wanted to do was go to the top of Marina Bay Sands. We bought the tickets and went up for the view.

Singapore is beautiful from the ground. The skyline, the buildings, the waterfront and the way the city is organized all make an impression when you move through it. But seeing it from above takes that experience to another level.

From that height, the city becomes something you can almost read as a whole. The buildings, roads, water and carefully planned spaces fit together in a way that is difficult to appreciate when you are standing among them.

For me, that was the real pleasure of going up Marina Bay Sands. It was not simply about standing at a famous viewpoint. It was about seeing a city that already looked impressive at street level suddenly become a completely different picture from above.

The light show we almost missed

There was another experience at Marina Bay Sands that became memorable precisely because it was not planned properly.

When I was in Singapore alone before Pragati arrived, I had already heard about the evening light show around Gardens by the Bay. I tried to find it with a colleague, but we were not lucky. We could not figure out exactly where to go and completely missed it.

A few days later, Pragati and I were walking around Marina Bay Sands. We were getting hungry, and while looking for something to eat we happened to head towards Gardens by the Bay. We found a place where we could have a burger and coffee and, almost by accident, ended up near an area where people were gathering.

Only then did we realize what was about to happen.

The lights came on.

We had not planned this second attempt at all. We had simply been walking around, looking for food, and had happened to arrive at the right place at the right time.

The show began, and we were pleasantly surprised.

It was one of those small travel moments that stays with you because of the way it happened. I had deliberately tried to find the show a few days earlier and failed. With Pragati, we found it without really looking for it.

The giant tree-like structures of Gardens by the Bay were already impressive to Pragati. Seeing them illuminated in the evening made the place even more striking. What could easily have been just another item on a sightseeing list became one of the moments we would remember from Singapore.

The Singapore of icons

There are some places in Singapore that almost everyone visiting for the first time will encounter.

Marina Bay Sands is one. The Merlion Park is another.

SINGAPORE

We visited Merlion Park too. The Merlion has become one of those instantly recognizable symbols of Singapore, and seeing it in person is almost part of the introduction to the city.

But there is another place that has a completely different kind of importance for an Indian traveller — Mustafa Centre.

If you asked a South Indian traveller which is more important, Merlion Park or Mustafa Centre, I think we all know the answer.

We spent significant time at Mustafa, walking around and shopping. There was a time when India's economy was much less open than it is today, and people travelling to Singapore often returned with items from places like Mustafa as souvenirs for relatives, friends and themselves.

For many Indian travellers, therefore, Mustafa was not just another shopping centre. It represented access to things that were less easily available back home. Walking through it brought some of that older memory of Singapore travel back to me.

Little India added another familiar dimension to the city, while Chinatown offered a very different cultural setting. We also visited malls including VivoCity and Bugis Junction.

Singapore managed to feel international without becoming difficult to navigate.

Getting around

One of the things I particularly appreciated was the public transport system.

It was easy to use trains and buses, and the ability to move around with a common transport card made getting from one part of the city to another simple. There was very little sense that a taxi or private car was necessary for ordinary sightseeing.

That convenience changes the way you experience a city. When public transport is reliable and straightforward, you can simply decide to go somewhere and go. There is less friction between wanting to see something and actually reaching it.

Singapore was exceptionally clean and organized, but what impressed me was that this organization did not feel like an obstacle to living in the city. It seemed to make movement easier.

A small problem at Universal Studios

We also visited Universal Studios Singapore.

The park itself was good, but we encountered one surprisingly practical problem: food.

Singapore had otherwise been an easy destination for us from a vegetarian-food perspective. Indian vegetarian food was readily available, and food in the city was never really a concern. Universal Studios was different.

There were plenty of restaurants, but many of the options were Malaysian, Singaporean or Chinese, with menus that were predominantly non-vegetarian. Finding something suitable for us was therefore harder than we expected.

It was a small problem, but it was also a reminder that even in a city where vegetarian Indian food is easy to find, a particular tourist attraction can be a completely different experience.

Singapore and Dubai

Having lived in Dubai and travelled there many times, I naturally found myself comparing Singapore with it.

I would rate Singapore even above Dubai.

SINGAPORE

Pragati would disagree with me. For her, Dubai is still the better city.

My own description of Singapore is that it is almost like Dubai without the harsh summer. It has the modern infrastructure, organization, cleanliness and sense of a carefully built city, but the climate makes being outdoors and moving around much more pleasant for much of the year.

That comparison is obviously personal. Cities are not really competitions, and Dubai has its own character that Singapore cannot reproduce. But having experienced both, Singapore felt like a place where the same love of modernity and organization existed alongside a greener and more tropical environment.

The beginning, not the end

Looking back, the March 2023 trip was unusual because it was both an ending and a beginning.

It ended the first part of my Singapore experience as a work-only destination. For those first few days, I was there because my office had sent me.

Then Pragati arrived, and Singapore became a place we could explore together.

We went to Marina Bay Sands, Gardens by the Bay, Merlion Park, Little India, Chinatown and Universal Studios. We shopped at Mustafa and visited malls such as VivoCity and Bugis Junction. We used the city's excellent public transport and discovered some things deliberately and others entirely by accident.

The light show at Gardens by the Bay was perhaps the perfect example. I had tried to find it when I was alone and failed. With Pragati, we stumbled upon it while looking for food.

TRAVELOGUE

That is often how travel works. The things we carefully plan are not always the things we remember most. Sometimes a wrong turn, an unplanned walk or simply being in the right place at the right time creates the stronger memory.

Singapore had been on my list for years. When I finally got there, it arrived through work, just as Australia had years earlier. But unlike Australia, I did not have to finish the personal part of the journey alone. Pragati came to join me, and that made this first Singapore trip particularly special.

I did not know then that I would return to Singapore many more times because of work.

So this was not really the end of my Singapore travels.

It was the beginning.

Sri Lanka



March 16–21, 2022

Some journeys begin with a carefully constructed plan. Others begin when the plan falls apart.

Sri Lanka was supposed to be a fairly straightforward road trip. It was another birthday journey with Pragati, and as with some of our earlier trips, one of the reasons for choosing the destination was the relative ease of obtaining a visa. Sri Lanka was close to home, easy to reach from Chennai, and seemed ideal for a few days of driving around the island.

The plan was simple: fly to Colombo, pick up a rental car and drive.

It did not quite work out that way.

A Birthday Journey

We flew from Chennai to Colombo on March 16, 2022, on SriLankan Airlines. I had originally booked an economy ticket, but there was an opportunity to pay for an upgrade to business class. I took it.

There was something nice about beginning a birthday trip that way.

We landed in Colombo expecting the rental car to be waiting and the road journey to begin. Instead, the first conversation with the rental company changed everything.

Sri Lanka was in the middle of a severe economic crisis. One of the immediate consequences for anyone trying to travel around the country was the shortage of fuel. The rental company could give us a car, but they could not guarantee that there would be enough petrol available for us to use it.

A car without fuel was not much of a road-trip vehicle.

Our original first destination was Dambulla, several hundred kilometres away, and we had planned to drive there ourselves. Now we had no car and no clear transport plan.

So I did what seemed like the most practical thing at that moment.

I booked an Uber.

The idea was simply to find someone who could take us to our hotel in Dambulla. We would figure out the rest once we got there.

That decision ended up shaping the entire trip.

The Uber Driver Who Became Our Driver

During the journey, the driver asked us about our plans.

We explained that we had intended to rent a car and travel around Sri Lanka, but the fuel situation had made that uncertain.

He offered us an alternative.

Why not let him drive us for the whole trip?

He was a local. He knew the roads, knew the situation on the ground and was confident that he could find fuel. He would take us wherever we wanted to go, stay with us through the journey and eventually drop us back at the airport.

It was an unexpected solution to an unexpected problem.

Just like that, our failed rental-car plan became a road journey with someone who knew the country far better than we did.

With transport sorted, we could finally stop worrying about how we were going to move around and start enjoying the trip.

Dambulla

Our first stop was Dambulla.

We visited the Dambulla Cave Temple, with its large Buddha statues and cave shrines. Getting there involved a substantial climb, and I remember thinking that this was going to be the toughest physical part of the trip.

I was wrong.

At the time, I had no idea that the next day's climb at Sigiriya would make Dambulla seem easy.

The journey through Dambulla also gave us our first real sense of travelling through Sri Lanka rather than simply arriving in another country. The road, the landscape and the rhythm of the place were beginning to replace the uncertainty of the first few hours.

We also visited Hurulu Eco Park, where we went on a jeep safari to see wild elephants.

Seeing elephants moving freely in their natural surroundings was one of the memorable experiences of the trip. There was something very

different about seeing them this way rather than encountering them in a controlled setting.

By the time the safari was over, it was already getting late. We had lunch almost towards evening and then returned to our hotel.

Our stay was at Liyya Water Villas, a peaceful property in Dambulla where isolated cottages were arranged around man-made lakes.

After a day of travelling and climbing, the setting was exactly what we needed.

It was calm.

Sigiriya

The next day brought the climb I had not anticipated.

Sigiriya.

The ancient rock fortress rose above us, and the climb looked daunting even before we started.

This time, Pragati decided that she had had enough of climbing.

She asked to be excused and stayed in the park below while I continued with a guide.

The climb was hectic. By then I had already learnt that Sri Lanka was not going to be a holiday where we simply moved from one comfortable stop to another.

But reaching the top made the effort worthwhile.

The view stretched out below us, and there was something satisfying about finally looking down at the landscape after having spent so much energy climbing up.

The history associated with Sigiriya added another dimension to the experience. Standing there made the place feel much larger than just another sightseeing stop on a road trip.

After coming back down, we visited a local crafts village and then a gem factory.

Sri Lanka's precious and semi-precious stones were displayed in all their variety. Some of them were beautiful enough to make buying one tempting.

Then we saw the prices.

We admired them and moved on.

Sometimes the easiest souvenir to take home is the one you decide not to buy.

From Dambulla to Kandy

We checked out of Liyya Water Villas and continued our journey towards Kandy.

One of the memorable stops there was the Temple of the Tooth, where the sacred tooth relic of the Buddha is kept.

It was a particularly interesting time to visit because it was a full-moon day. The place was crowded, with large numbers of Buddhist devotees coming to the temple.

The atmosphere was very different from the tourist attractions we had visited earlier.

This was not simply a historical monument.

For the people gathered there, it was a place of deep religious significance.

From Kandy we continued towards Nuwara Eliya, travelling through the hill country. On the way we stopped at Glenloch Tea Factory.

The landscape was changing as we climbed higher, and by the time we reached Nuwara Eliya, the weather had changed with it.

Nuwara Eliya and the Ramayana Connection

Nuwara Eliya was not chosen randomly.

One of the reasons I wanted to come here was its connection with the Ramayana.

According to the tradition associated with the site, this was the place where Ravana kept Sita in Ashoka Vana.

We visited the temple associated with that story.

There was something special about standing in a place outside India and encountering a story that had been part of our cultural memory for generations.

Travel sometimes makes familiar stories feel different.

You know them from books, conversations, television and childhood memories. Then suddenly you find yourself standing somewhere that is connected to that story.

It was one of those moments when the distance between India and Sri Lanka seemed to disappear.

Our hotel in Nuwara Eliya was a small, pleasant place called La Grande Villa.

It was cold and raining outside, while the hotel itself was warm and cozy.

After the heat and activity of Dambulla and the climb at Sigiriya, the change was welcome.

A Detour into a Family's Life

The next day we checked out and started the drive towards Bentota. Somewhere along the journey, our driver made an unusual suggestion. His family lived in a village along the way.

He had been travelling with us for a couple of days and had been away from his family during that time. He wanted to stop and meet them.

So we did.

We stopped at his village and spent some time there while he met his family.

It was a small detour, but one that I remember because it wasn't part of our itinerary at all.

We had started the trip with a stranger we had found through an Uber booking.

Now that same person had become our driver, guide and travel companion, and we were sitting in his village while he caught up with his family.

It was one of those experiences that no itinerary could have planned. Eventually we said goodbye and continued towards Bentota.

Bentota

By the time we reached Bentota, we were ready to stop moving.

The Avani Bentota Resort was exactly what we needed at that point in the journey.

It had a private beach and a swimming pool, and after several days of travelling through the country, we finally allowed ourselves to slow down.

There was no major sightseeing agenda.

We rested.

Sometimes a good trip needs a day where nothing much happens.

Bentota gave us that pause.

After the climbing, driving, temples, wildlife and changing landscapes of the previous days, the calm felt almost like a reward.

Colombo and the Journey Home

Our flight back to Chennai was on March 21.

We checked out, collected our luggage and headed towards Colombo rather than going directly to the airport.

There was still time for some local shopping and sightseeing.

Among the things I bought was a wooden statue of Buddha.

It was a small reminder of the journey we had just completed.

And then it was time to say goodbye to our driver.

He had entered our trip almost by accident.

We had needed an Uber simply to get from Colombo to Dambulla after our rental-car plan collapsed. Instead, we found someone who stayed with us for the entire journey, drove us across the country, helped us navigate a difficult fuel situation and eventually brought us back to the airport.

The journey had started with a problem.

It ended with a handshake and a goodbye to someone who had become an important part of the trip.

Travelling Through a Crisis

There was another unusual aspect to this journey.

When we arrived in Sri Lanka, the country was already facing an economic crisis. Fuel availability was a major concern, and the uncertainty was visible in everyday travel.

But there was another effect that we noticed during our short stay.

The Sri Lankan rupee was depreciating rapidly.

Between the day we arrived and the day we were leaving, the exchange rate had moved noticeably in our favour. For every rupee or dollar we exchanged, we were getting more Sri Lankan rupees.

As visitors carrying foreign currency, this made many things feel surprisingly inexpensive.

That became one of the strange highlights of the journey.

We were travelling through a beautiful country at a time when the people living there were dealing with a serious economic crisis. What felt inexpensive to us as visitors was, of course, part of a much larger and more difficult situation for the country.

It was an uncomfortable contradiction to observe.

Travel can sometimes put you in situations where your experience as a visitor is very different from the reality of the people who live there.

Sri Lanka gave us one of those reminders.

A Country We Almost Overlook

Looking back, perhaps the most interesting thing about Sri Lanka is how close it is to home.

We often think of travel as something that requires long flights, complicated planning and distant destinations.

But Sri Lanka is hardly an hour's flight from Chennai.

It is right there, across the water.

And yet, like many travellers, we can sometimes become so interested in places far away that we overlook the gems that are close to us.

Our Sri Lanka trip was supposed to be a road trip with a rental car.

Instead, an economic crisis took away the car, a last-minute Uber booking gave us a driver, and that unexpected change gave us a journey we could never have planned.

We climbed ancient sites, watched elephants roam freely, travelled through tea country, followed a story from the Ramayana, met our driver's family, rested beside the sea and ended the journey with a wooden Buddha statue in our luggage.

Sometimes the best journeys are not the ones that go according to plan.

They are the ones that force you to change the plan and, in doing so, show you something you would otherwise have missed.

Sri Lanka was one of those journeys.

And perhaps the lesson was simpler still:

We don't always have to look far away to find somewhere worth travelling to.

Thailand



A New Year trip that began in a country in mourning

Thailand was an easy choice for a New Year trip from Dubai. For an Indian traveller, the visa-on-arrival process made the country particularly convenient, and that simplicity was part of the reason Pragati and I chose it.

We left Dubai on the night of 29 December 2016, taking the midnight flight to Bangkok. The flight was listed as 30 December, and that small detail became one of those travel-date quirks that is worth remembering. We had left one year behind and were heading towards a New Year in Thailand.

What we did not expect was that the country would be experiencing a very different kind of moment.

King Bhumibol Adulyadej had died in October 2016, aged 88. Thailand was still in a period of mourning when we arrived. The country had announced that New Year celebrations would be muted, and that

changed the atmosphere of what we had imagined would be a festive trip.

Bangkok before the New Year

Our first few days were spent in Bangkok. We stayed at the Courtyard by Marriott Bangkok, and began with some of the places we had come to see: Wat Arun, the Grand Palace and Wat Phra.

Bangkok had the energy I expected from a huge Asian city, but the mood around the New Year was different. On 31 December, after local sightseeing, we went towards CentralWorld, which was close enough to our hotel to walk to.

There were plenty of people around. It was clear that many wanted to celebrate the arrival of the New Year. Yet the circumstances of the country meant that this was not going to be the kind of New Year's Eve we had imagined.

There was no fireworks display and no countdown.

That absence became one of the strongest memories of the trip. We had travelled to Thailand specifically around New Year, expecting the excitement that normally comes with it. Instead, we found ourselves in a country still mourning its king. The contrast was striking: people were there, the desire to celebrate was there, but the celebration itself was deliberately subdued.

It was a reminder that travel is not simply about arriving at a destination with your own plans. You arrive in the middle of somebody else's history too.

Floating through Bangkok

New Year's Day gave us a completely different experience. We visited Wat Saphan Floating Market and Khlong Lad Mayom Floating Market, using Grab to get there.

The markets offered a different side of Bangkok from the monumental sights of the previous days. Instead of temples and grand buildings, the experience was much more connected to the city's waterways and everyday life.

We also took a speed boat ride in the Bang Phrom River. Water became an unexpected theme of our Bangkok days. Later in the trip, we would spend even more time travelling by boat on the Chao Phraya River.

I remember these experiences not as a checklist of attractions, but as a way of seeing Bangkok differently. The city could be explored from roads, markets and temples, but the waterways gave it another character altogether.

Bangkok to Pattaya

On 3 January, we left Bangkok for Pattaya by bus from Bangkok Bus Terminal (Eastern). Pattaya was the second part of the trip, and we checked into the Courtyard by Marriott Pattaya.

There was local sightseeing and, naturally, water sports.

The most memorable episode was parasailing. Pragati could not do it, but we had already bought two tickets. Rather than let the second ticket go unused, I did something that still makes me smile: I went parasailing twice.

Sometimes travel produces memories because something went exactly as planned. Sometimes it produces them because the plan did not work for everyone and you improvise. This was definitely the second kind.

We also took a boat to Ko Lan and spent time on the beach. The island is a popular vacation destination, known for its beaches and natural

surroundings. For us, it was simply another change of pace after the intensity of Bangkok.

Back to Bangkok

After Pattaya, we returned to Bangkok by bus and checked into the Novotel Bangkok Fenix Silom for the final part of the trip.

The last days were less about major sightseeing and more about experiencing the city at our own pace. We went shopping, spent time in Chinatown and visited the Sri Maha Mariamman Temple, also known as Wat Khaek.

The temple was another interesting connection to the Indian presence in Thailand. We also ate at Saravana Bhavan in Bangkok, which gave us a familiar taste of home in the middle of an international trip.

And there was more time on the water. We took many speedboat rides on the Chao Phraya River, making the river one of the recurring experiences of our Bangkok stay.

Looking back

Thailand gave us many of the things we had expected from a holiday: Bangkok, beaches, water sports, markets, boats, shopping and a change of scene. But the memory that has stayed with me most strongly is something we could not have planned.

We had gone to Thailand for New Year because it was an easy destination for us to enter and seemed like a good place to welcome another year. Instead, we arrived only a couple of months after the death of King Bhumibol Adulyadej and experienced a country in mourning.

Standing near CentralWorld on New Year's Eve, surrounded by people who clearly wanted to celebrate but without the fireworks and

THAILAND

countdown we had expected, was strangely memorable. It was not the New Year celebration we had travelled for, but it became the defining moment of the trip.

That is one of the things I have come to appreciate about travel. You can choose the country, the dates, the hotel and the flights. You cannot choose the historical moment into which you arrive.

Thailand was our New Year trip. But instead of remembering it for a spectacular countdown, I remember it for the silence that replaced one.

Part III — Europe

Switzerland



The final chapter of our European journey

Switzerland was not a separate holiday for us. It was the final stop of our 2016 European journey — a journey that had begun in Rome and taken us through Florence, Pisa, Venice and Milan before we reached Zurich.

We had deliberately kept the trip open-ended. We knew where we were starting and where we eventually needed to fly home from, but we did not have every day planned in advance. As we moved north through Italy, the journey itself became the plan.

By the time we reached Zurich, we had already learnt something important about the way we liked to travel.

Arriving in Zurich

Zurich felt different from the Italian cities we had just travelled through.

There wasn't a long list of monuments we were determined to tick off. Instead, Zurich became a place to slow down and simply experience the city before returning to Dubai.

We stayed near Zurich station, which turned out to be an excellent choice. After several days of moving between cities, being close to a major transport hub made everything easy. We could walk out, find our way around and use public transport without having to worry about complicated arrangements.

And the public transport itself made an impression on me.

Buses, trams, trains and ferries seemed to fit together seamlessly. It was the sort of system that made moving around feel almost effortless. Everything also appeared remarkably clean and organised.

For someone who enjoys figuring out how a city works, that was part of the attraction.

A different kind of sightseeing

Our time in Zurich wasn't about rushing from one famous attraction to another.

We walked around, used public transport and simply enjoyed being there. After the movement and sightseeing of Rome, Florence, Pisa and Venice, the slower pace felt welcome.

There was also something satisfying about arriving in a new city and being able to navigate it without needing a car. The buses, trams, trains and ferries gave us the freedom to move around while staying close to the station.

In that sense, Zurich fitted perfectly into what this trip had become.

We had started the journey without a detailed plan. We had learnt to book accommodation and train journeys as we went. We had

SWITZERLAND

discovered that we could move between cities without needing to know exactly what the next day would look like.

Zurich was the final proof that this way of travelling worked for us.

The end of the journey

There was a certain symmetry to the trip.

We had entered Europe through Rome and were leaving from Zurich. Between those two points, we had travelled through several cities, changed trains, dealt with accommodation as we went and gradually become more comfortable with uncertainty.

Zurich was therefore more than another destination on the map. It was where the whole experiment came together.

After ten days on the road through Italy and Switzerland, we boarded our Emirates flight from Zurich back to Dubai on 25 August 2016.

There was no grand finale. We simply went home.

But looking back, Zurich remains an important part of that journey because it represented what we had learnt along the way.

We had discovered that we could travel without planning every detail. We could make decisions on the road, use public transport, choose accommodation as we went and still have a wonderful time.

Switzerland wasn't really another trip added to our travel history.

It was the place where one journey ended – and where we became a little more confident about travelling on our own terms.

Italy



Learning how we wanted to travel

Italy was an important trip for us. Georgia had been our first personal international trip, and it had also taught us a few lessons about what could go wrong when we made the wrong choices. Italy became the next experiment: could we travel with much less planning and still have a good experience?

The answer, over ten days, was a very definite yes.

We travelled from Dubai to Rome on 16 August 2016 and returned from Zurich on 25 August. The broad plan was simple: enter Europe through Rome and leave from Zurich. Everything in between could be decided as we went.

Why Italy

One of the practical reasons for choosing Italy was that the Italian embassy in Dubai made the Schengen visa process relatively easy for us. But the trip was also about experimenting with European travel, particularly the possibility of moving between cities by train.

ITALY

We had learnt from Georgia that location matters. On that trip we had chosen a hotel far from the centre of the city, and travelling back and forth became a constant challenge. We had also booked accommodation through Booking.com that turned out to be a house hosted by a couple rather than the kind of hotel we expected. We did not enjoy that experience and changed immediately to a nearby hotel.

In Italy we tried to make better choices without turning the whole journey into a rigid itinerary.

Rome

Rome seems to have history in every corner. We visited the Colosseum, Vatican City, the Trevi Fountain, the Spanish Steps, the Pantheon and Piazza del Campidoglio.

The Colosseum was a particular favourite. One evening Pragati decided to rest at the hotel, and I travelled alone back towards the Colosseum with my camera. Having the freedom to go out simply to photograph something I wanted to see was one of the small pleasures of the trip.

We used the city sightseeing bus as well as local buses and other public transport. Rome was our introduction to travelling around a European city without needing a car.

The city also set the tone for the trip in another way. We were not trying to understand Rome in a single day or reduce it to a checklist. We were simply moving through it, stopping where something caught our attention and allowing the city to become familiar at its own pace.

The journey north

From Rome we took the train to Florence. We had not planned every detail in advance. The next stay and the next journey were booked as we moved along.

Florence was partly a stop between Rome and Venice. We did not spend a great deal of time sightseeing there, although I remember walking around Piazza del Duomo in the evening.

The main reason for stopping in Florence was to make the journey to Pisa.

Pisa

The train from Florence to Pisa was itself memorable — a double-decker train, something that was new to us at the time.

After getting off at Pisa station, we took a bus to the Leaning Tower.

And yes, Pisa was exactly what you expect it to be: the tower was tilting. Seeing it in person after having seen it so many times in photographs was still a wonderful experience.

There was something satisfying about that stop precisely because it was simple. We did not need to spend days there. We arrived, saw the tower, photographed it and moved on.

Venice

Venice was beautiful and had its own rhythm.

We stayed near the Rialto Bridge and visited St Mark's Square. The weather could change dramatically. At one point it suddenly started raining. Within minutes vendors appeared from different corners selling ponchos, and then just as quickly the rain passed.

ITALY

St Mark's Square had a character of its own. If I return to Venice, I would spend more time there rather than trying to cover too much of the city.

The accommodation brought another lesson. We had booked a place near Rialto, but the directions and arrangements for getting the key were not clear. We made a call after reaching the area, and someone from the crowd came looking for us, asked our name and handed us a key. The room was on the second floor, breakfast was in the kitchen, and when we left we were simply told to leave the key near the door.

It was another reminder that accommodation booked online does not always look like the conventional hotel experience you imagine from the booking page.

Milan and the journey to Zurich

Milan was barely a stop for us. We changed trains there and did not really enter the city.

That was intentional in a way. This trip was not about ticking every famous attraction. It was about discovering how land travel between European cities worked and seeing how much could be done without planning every hour.

From Milan we continued to Zurich, which was our planned exit point.

Zurich

Zurich surprised us with its public transport. Buses, trams, trains and ferries all seemed to fit together seamlessly, and everything was remarkably clean.

We chose to stay near the station, which made much of the city accessible on foot. After the movement through Italy, Zurich was a

comfortable place to slow down for the final two nights before flying back to Dubai.

Looking back, Zurich was almost the natural conclusion to the experiment that had started in Rome. We had spent the trip moving between places, learning how to use trains and public transport, and making decisions as we went. By the time we reached Zurich, we had become comfortable with that way of travelling.

What Italy taught us

The biggest memory I have of Italy is not one monument. It is the experience of making decisions as we went.

We arrived in Rome knowing where we were starting. We knew we would eventually leave from Zurich. In between, we booked trains and accommodation along the way and let the journey develop.

There were plenty of moving parts, but everything fell into place. Over ten days we travelled through Rome, Florence, Pisa, Venice and Milan before reaching Zurich, with no major glitch.

That gave us something more valuable than a successful holiday: confidence.

Georgia had taught us that travel does require some thought. A hotel far from the centre can make every day difficult. An accommodation listing can turn out to be very different from what you imagined.

Italy taught us something different: **travel can be fun even when it is unplanned, provided you make the right choices.**

That lesson stayed with us and gave us the confidence to approach many of our future journeys with less fear of uncertainty.

Looking back

ITALY

Italy was therefore much more than a trip through some of Europe's most famous cities. It was the point at which we began to understand the kind of travellers we wanted to be.

We did not need to know exactly where we would sleep a week later. We did not need to plan every train before leaving Dubai. We could walk, use public transport, book something along the way and adapt.

The uncertainty did not make the trip difficult. It made it more interesting.

And that is probably what I remember most about Italy: **we learnt that we could travel.**

Portugal



I had always wanted to do a big road trip in Europe. This time, I thought I was finally going to do it.

I had obtained my International Driving Permit, got the visa from Dubai, and had even researched apps that I thought would help me find a rental car. The plan was to fly to Lisbon, rent a car there and return it in Madrid. From there, we would continue through Spain and, if things worked out, perhaps even make it to France.

As usual, the return was deliberately kept open-ended.

Pragati and I flew from Dubai to Lisbon on 29 November 2018. Once we landed, we took an Uber to the hotel. It was the beginning of winter and the weather was beautiful — cool, comfortable and with Lisbon wrapped in mist and fog.

We were staying at the TURIM Av. Liberdade Hotel. One of the lessons we had learnt from earlier travels was to stay close to the centre, and

this hotel worked very well for us. It was close to a metro station, which made getting around easy, and there was a restaurant right downstairs from our room.

Lisbon in the mist

We took the metro to Praça do Comércio. Lisbon in the mist had a character of its own. We walked around the square for a while and then took a cab to Belém.

Belém Tower was beautiful. While we were there, a sudden shower passed through, leaving everything lush and wet. For a photographer, it was almost perfect. The wet paved paths reflected the surroundings, and I remember using the water left by the shower to create a reflection photograph of Belém Tower.

There were plenty of people around, walking, exploring and enjoying the place. The atmosphere was relaxed and lively at the same time.

For a moment, the road trip still felt completely real. We had arrived in Lisbon, the car was supposed to come next, and there was an entire route ahead of us. The city was simply the beginning.

But while Lisbon was treating us well, the trip was beginning to change.

When the plan changed

Pragati had already been uncomfortable, and her condition gradually became worse. We tried to push through it, but eventually there came a point when we had to accept that continuing with a long road trip in that condition wasn't sensible.

The original plan had not included a flight from Lisbon to Madrid. Why would it? We were supposed to drive there.

So I booked an EasyJet flight instead.

It was disappointing. I had imagined driving through Portugal and Spain, perhaps crossing into France, stopping wherever we felt like stopping and discovering Europe from the road. Instead, we were suddenly on a flight to Madrid because circumstances had left us with little choice.

Health had to take priority.

That was probably the hardest part of the trip — not that anything dramatic had happened, but that a journey I had spent time preparing for simply stopped being possible.

Madrid without the road trip

After reaching Madrid, Pragati still wasn't feeling well, so I spent much of the remaining time exploring on my own. I walked around Madrid and photographed whatever caught my attention.

El Retiro Park was beautiful, and the Palacio de Cristal in particular was amazing. There were plenty of people around and street artists adding to the atmosphere. I spent time walking, looking and photographing.

I also photographed the Madrid-Puerta de Atocha-Almudena Grandes railway station.

The flight from Lisbon to Madrid gave me one last reminder of the journey we had originally imagined. Looking down from the aircraft, the landscape between the two cities looked wonderful. I remember thinking how much better it would have been to experience that landscape from a car, slowly making our way through the countryside.

That road trip never happened.

Making the best of what remained

Food, as always, was one of the minor challenges of travelling outside India. By then we had become quite used to it. We would find something vegetarian somewhere, and quite often Google would lead us to an Indian restaurant. It was no longer something that could derail a trip.

The trip itself, though, had already changed course.

What was supposed to be a long European road adventure became a short visit to Lisbon followed by Madrid. We had to give up the rental-car plan, the drive through Spain and the possibility of reaching France. We even brought the return journey forward.

Yet the trip was not completely lost. Lisbon gave me mist, rain and a chance to photograph Belém Tower in conditions I would never have planned. Madrid gave me time to walk, photograph and explore at my own pace while Pragati recovered. The journey was different, but it was still ours.

Looking back

This could have been a trip of our lifetime if everything had gone according to plan. The preparations were there, the idea was there and the excitement was certainly there.

But things don't always go according to plan.

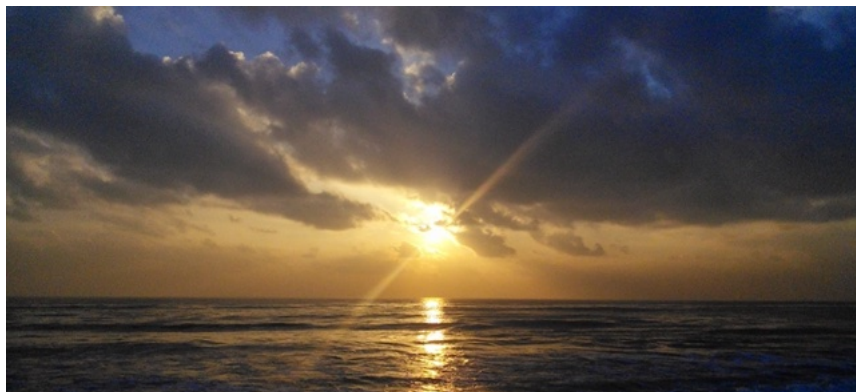
Life is unpredictable, and we all have to accept it.

Perhaps that is why I still remember this journey so clearly. The thing I remember most is not what we saw, but what we had to give up — and how quickly we learnt to accept it.

Somewhere between the mist of Lisbon, the rain on the paths of Belém, the landscape below an EasyJet flight and my walks through Madrid, there was still a journey worth remembering.

The road trip never happened. The memory did.

Spain



The road trip that changed course

Spain was supposed to be part of a much bigger European road trip.

Pragati and I had arrived in Lisbon on 29 November 2018 with the idea of renting a car, driving from Portugal into Spain and perhaps continuing towards France. I had obtained my International Driving Permit, researched rental-car options and was looking forward to experiencing Europe from the road rather than from trains and flights.

It didn't work out that way.

Pragati had already been uncomfortable in Lisbon, and her condition gradually became worse. At some point, continuing a long road journey simply stopped making sense. The original plan depended on being able to drive comfortably from one place to another, and we had to accept that circumstances had changed.

So instead of driving from Lisbon to Madrid, I booked an EasyJet flight.

It was disappointing. I had imagined the countryside between Portugal and Spain unfolding slowly through a car window. Instead, we crossed the distance by air because health had to come first.

Madrid

Madrid became an unexpected destination in its own right.

Pragati was still not feeling well, so much of my time in Madrid was spent exploring on my own. That gave me a different kind of freedom. I didn't have a fixed sightseeing list to complete. I could simply walk around with my camera and stop wherever something caught my attention.

El Retiro Park was one of those places. I spent time walking through the park and photographing the surroundings. The Palacio de Cristal was particularly impressive, and the combination of the architecture, the park and the people around it gave me plenty to look at through the camera.

There were street artists adding another layer to the atmosphere. Madrid felt alive without requiring me to follow a rigid itinerary.

I also spent time photographing the Madrid-Puerta de Atocha-Almudena Grandes railway station. After having travelled through Europe by train on other journeys, railway stations had begun to interest me as much as conventional tourist attractions. They are places where people are constantly arriving, leaving and passing through.

Looking back at the road

The most memorable part of Spain was actually the journey that never happened.

From the aircraft on the Lisbon–Madrid flight, I looked down at the landscape between the two cities and imagined how different it would have felt to travel through it by car. We would have been able to stop when we wanted, take photographs, discover small places and simply enjoy the road.

Instead, we were flying over it.

That moment brought home how completely the trip had changed.

The original European road adventure had included Portugal, Spain and possibly France. The rental car never happened. The long drive never happened. The return journey was eventually brought forward as well.

But Madrid still gave me something valuable. While Pragati recovered, I had the opportunity to slow down, walk through the city and photograph it without worrying about covering a checklist of attractions.

An unexpected part of the journey

Spain therefore doesn't really stand alone in our travel history. It is closely tied to Portugal and to the European road trip we had imagined in 2018.

Portugal was where the plan began to unravel. Madrid was where we adapted to it.

I had started the journey wanting to drive across Europe. I ended up taking a flight into Madrid and exploring the city on foot with a camera.

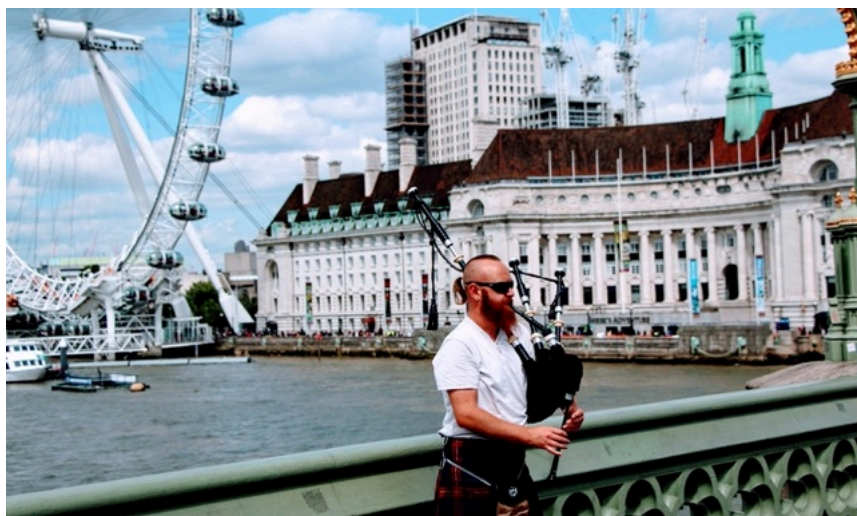
It wasn't the journey I had planned.

But it was still a journey worth remembering.

Sometimes a destination becomes part of your travel history not because you chose it deliberately, but because circumstances lead you there.

Madrid was one of those places for me.

United Kingdom



London, friends and the road north

Our United Kingdom trip in June 2017 was different from many of our earlier journeys. Pragati and I were travelling together, but this time the trip was also about spending time with close friends. Pradeep had recently moved into his home in Ilford and insisted that we stay with him and Kalaivalli for the entire trip rather than book a hotel.

That decision shaped the trip more than we probably realised at the time. We weren't simply arriving in London, checking into a hotel and following an itinerary. We were arriving at a friend's home, being picked up from the airport, sharing meals and then heading out each day to discover the city. Later, when Pradeep and Kalaivalli joined us for the Scotland tour, the trip became a proper group journey.

Arriving in London

We flew from Dubai to London Heathrow on Emirates flight EK003 on 1 June 2017. Pradeep came to pick us up at the airport, and from Heathrow we made our way towards Ilford using London's rail network.

For someone visiting London for the first time, the scale of the transport system is one of the things that immediately makes an impression. The Underground is not simply a way of getting from one tourist attraction to another; it is part of how London functions. During this trip, it became our default way of moving around the city, making it possible to cover very different parts of London without having to think too much about road traffic or parking.

Our first stop was Westfield Stratford City, the huge shopping and entertainment complex in Stratford. It was an easy way to begin the trip without trying to pack a major sightseeing programme into the first few hours after arriving.

The following day, 2 June, we went to Greenwich Park. Greenwich is much more than just another London park. It is closely associated with Britain's maritime history and with the Royal Observatory, whose location is tied to the Prime Meridian and Greenwich Mean Time. The area brings together the park, the observatory, historic buildings and views across London, making it one of those places where geography and history are both part of the experience.

For us, though, the more immediate memory was simply being there with Pradeep and beginning to settle into the rhythm of London.

From London to Scotland

On the morning of 3 June, the character of the trip changed completely.

We left London for a four-day Historic Scotland tour organised by Star Tours. Pradeep and Kalaivalli joined us, turning what had started as a trip for two into a group road journey.

There is something different about seeing a country from a road rather than moving between airports and city centres. As we travelled north, London gradually gave way to a very different landscape. The road itself became part of the experience, with the changing scenery providing a continuous introduction to Scotland before we even reached the cities.

We reached Glasgow by evening and stayed at Jurys Inn Glasgow as part of the tour. Glasgow is Scotland's largest city and has a long industrial and maritime history, but our visit was relatively brief. We saw Glasgow Cathedral and George Square before continuing with the tour.

Glasgow Cathedral was particularly interesting in the context of the city. It is one of Scotland's great medieval buildings and one of the few medieval churches on the Scottish mainland to survive the Reformation largely intact. George Square, by contrast, represents a much more civic face of Glasgow, surrounded by public buildings and monuments to figures from Scottish and British history.

The road journey between places was just as memorable as the stops themselves. Scotland has a way of making the landscape feel larger than the map suggests, and travelling through the countryside gave the trip a sense of scale that a city visit alone could never provide.

Edinburgh and the Highlands

The tour also took us to Edinburgh, Scotland's capital and one of the country's most recognisable historic cities. Edinburgh has a particularly distinctive character because of the contrast between its medieval Old Town and the planned Georgian New Town. The Royal

Mile runs through the historic Old Town, connecting Edinburgh Castle with the Palace of Holyroodhouse and passing through one of the most historically significant parts of the city.

Our visit was part of a larger road tour, so Edinburgh was one chapter in a much broader Scottish journey rather than a standalone city break. That made the experience different from the way we explored London. We were constantly moving, seeing a little more of Scotland with every leg of the journey.

One of the stops that stayed with me was Loch Tulla. A place like this makes it easy to understand why travelling through Scotland by road can be as rewarding as reaching any particular destination. Loch Tulla sits within the dramatic Highland landscape, with open water, mountains and broad stretches of countryside creating the kind of scenery that feels very different from the urban environment we had left behind in London.

We also visited Glengoyne Distillery. Glengoyne is a Highland single-malt whisky distillery just outside Glasgow, known for its deliberately slow distillation process. For us, it was another interesting contrast within the journey: after cities, roads and Highland scenery, we were seeing a part of Scotland's whisky-making tradition at its source.

The four-day tour gave us a taste of Scotland rather than an exhaustive exploration of it, but that was part of its appeal. We were not trying to master the country in four days. We were simply moving through it, stopping at places that gave us a sense of its history, landscape and character.

Back to London

The Scotland tour brought us back to London on 7 June. Returning to the city after several days on the road felt like changing gears again.

We still had time before our flight home, so we continued exploring London. This time the list included some of the city's most recognisable landmarks: the London Eye, Trafalgar Square, Big Ben, St Paul's Cathedral and Madame Tussauds.

The London Eye offered the familiar modern view of the city from above, while Trafalgar Square and the area around Big Ben placed us among some of the symbols most strongly associated with Britain's capital. St Paul's Cathedral added a very different kind of landmark — a major piece of London's architectural and religious history whose dome has been part of the city's skyline for centuries.

Madame Tussauds was a completely different experience again. The London attraction has a history stretching back to the nineteenth century, when Marie Tussaud established a permanent base in London, and the present Marylebone Road site dates from 1884. What began as a travelling exhibition of wax figures eventually became one of London's best-known attractions. By the time we visited, it was the familiar combination of celebrity figures, historical personalities and theatrical displays that visitors associate with the name.

Moving between these places was remarkably straightforward because we mostly relied on the Underground. That became one of the practical pleasures of the trip. London can appear intimidating on a map, but once you understand the Tube, the city becomes surprisingly accessible.

Food was another thing we never had to worry much about. Indian restaurants were easy to find, which made travelling with familiar food preferences particularly comfortable. It may sound like a small detail, but when you are travelling for several days, knowing that you can find food you are comfortable with takes away one more thing to think about.

More than a sightseeing trip

Looking back, I don't remember this trip primarily as a collection of landmarks.

I remember Pradeep picking us up from Heathrow. I remember staying in his home in Ilford rather than a hotel. I remember the change from exploring London with a friend to setting off on a road tour through Scotland with a larger group. I remember the Scottish countryside between the stops, the cities we passed through, Loch Tulla, and the experience of seeing a distillery in its own surroundings.

That is probably what made this journey different from many others. Travel is often described through destinations, but sometimes the people you travel with become the real destination of the memory.

It was also one of the relatively rare occasions when we travelled as a larger group rather than just Pragati and me. Pradeep and Kalaivalli were wonderful hosts, and their insistence that we stay with them made the London part of the journey feel less like a conventional holiday and more like visiting friends while discovering another country.

The Scotland road trip added another dimension. For four days we were not simply tourists based in one city; we were moving together through a landscape that was completely different from London, sharing the long stretches of road and the stops along the way.

We finally flew back from London Heathrow to Dubai on Emirates flight EK032 on 10 June 2017.

The United Kingdom trip therefore stayed with me not because of one spectacular moment, but because of the combination of friendship, hospitality, cities and a road journey through Scotland. It was one of those trips where the itinerary is easy to remember, but the people are what make the itinerary worth remembering.

Part IV — North America

USA



A First America for Both of Us

My trip to the United States in 2009 was not my first visit to America. But it was the first time I travelled there with Pragati, and for her, it was her first international trip. That alone gives this journey a place of its own in our travel memories.

The trip came together in the familiar way many of my journeys did in those years: work first, pleasure fitted around it. The multinational company I was working for in Delhi had its headquarters in Norwalk, Connecticut, and I also had a client visit to make. The two purposes were combined into roughly a month's stay.

This time, because I was travelling with my wife, the company was considerate enough to arrange a homestay for us. That made a significant difference. We had a small kitchen in the room, so on days when we did not feel like going out, we could cook something

ourselves. There was also a mall nearby, though the weather made even a five-minute walk impractical. We would take a cab even for that short distance.

Arriving in winter

We left Delhi on the night of 7 February. After the long flight, we reached the United States the following morning and made our way to Norwalk. An office-provided cab took us from the airport towards Connecticut, and after checking into the Homestead, the first day was mostly about settling in.

For me, the practicalities of a work trip began almost immediately. For Pragati, though, everything was new. She was excited, and she genuinely enjoyed the experience of being in another country for the first time.

My working days were filled with office visits, client work and the inevitable logistics of getting connected and getting things working. Even something as simple as finding the right power adapter for my laptop became part of the first few days. Colleagues were extraordinarily helpful. They picked us up, dropped us back, helped us get around and, in many ways, made it possible for us to experience the place while I was occupied with work.

And then there was the weather.

We were in the Homestead when we experienced our first snowfall. For both of us, it was something to be enjoyed rather than merely observed. We went outside and let ourselves get drenched in the snow. It was one of those simple experiences that needs no itinerary or landmark to make it memorable.

New York on Valentine's Day

Our first real outing was to New York on 14 February.

It happened to be Valentine's Day, and Times Square seemed to know it. Everything appeared to be red. After the relative quiet of our work surroundings, Times Square was a completely different experience — bright, crowded and constantly moving.

We took a city sightseeing bus and saw some of the familiar sights of New York, including the Statue of Liberty. For Pragati, this was not simply another sightseeing day. It was part of her first experience of an international city that she had probably known until then largely through photographs, television and films.

I also bought Pragati a Citizen Eco-Drive watch. That watch has survived all these years and she still has it. Looking back, it is funny how a small purchase can become a much stronger memory than many of the expensive things one sees on a trip.

The day also produced one of those very personal travel incidents that probably nobody else would remember. Pragati accidentally spilled coffee on my jeans, leaving a stain. I was not amused. I was thinking about the photographs I would be taking and how the stain was going to ruin them. It was hardly a major travel incident, but these are the kinds of details that remain when the exact sequence of a day has faded.

Working, wandering and discovering America

Most of the trip was still work. The weekdays were shaped by office schedules, meetings and getting from one place to another. But there were enough evenings and weekends to make the journey feel like more than a business trip.

We also discovered that shopping was almost part and parcel of the experience. We had seen malls in Delhi, of course, but American malls

felt completely different to us. There was an abundance of clothes, bags and things to browse through, and we enjoyed it.

A friend insisted that I buy a T-shirt from Abercrombie & Fitch. I bought it with some reluctance, but it turned out to be a surprisingly good purchase. We came back with handbags, clothes and the usual collection of things that somehow become part of an international trip.

One of the outings took us to a mall in Stamford. Another took us to New Haven, where we visited Yale and the Peabody Museum. The museum was memorable for its life-size dinosaur skeletons and fossils, along with the many other exhibits. Yale, too, was one of those names that felt very familiar even before we had seen the place in person.

New York, again

We returned to New York on 7 March, mainly to see some of the places we had missed on our first visit.

This time we went up the Empire State Building. It was probably our first experience of going up such a high-rise building simply to look out over a city. From that height, New York became a very different landscape.

We also spent time in Central Park and, inevitably, went back to Times Square. Times Square had already acquired a special place in our memories from the Valentine's Day visit, and it was still as bustling and alive as before.

We also went to the place where the Twin Towers had stood. In 2009, the site still felt remarkably blank to me. It was difficult to reconcile the empty space with the images of the towers that had become part of the world's collective memory after September 11.

There was also a pizza somewhere near the Empire State Building that tasted extraordinarily good that day. Whether it really was that good

or whether we were simply extremely hungry is impossible to say now. Perhaps the old saying is right: the taste of food is partly in the hunger.

A month that belonged to both work and travel

By the time we left, the trip had become much more than the client and headquarters visits that had brought me there.

For me, it was another work trip that had been made richer by the opportunity to explore. For Pragati, it was something much bigger: her first international journey. And for both of us, it was our first time experiencing snow together, our first New York outings together, our first high-rise city view of this scale and our first glimpse of everyday life in America.

But perhaps what stays with me most after all these years is not one landmark. It is the kindness of the people around us. Our colleagues did far more than simply help me get to work. They picked us up, dropped us back, helped us navigate an unfamiliar place and made sure that two people arriving from Delhi could experience something of the country beyond the office.

The exact details of a month from 2009 have inevitably softened with time. Some days have disappeared into the blur of work, and some places survive mainly through photographs. But Times Square remains vivid. So does the first snowfall. So does Pragati's excitement at seeing the world beyond India for the first time.

And somewhere in those memories is that pizza near the Empire State Building — still impossible to judge after all these years.

Part V — Oceania

Australia



The business trip that became a holiday

In December 2012, Melbourne came into my travel plans almost by accident.

I suddenly got an opportunity to travel there for an office seminar. The official part of the trip was only for two days, on 9 and 10 December. But once the work opportunity appeared, I decided not to come all the way to Australia for just two days. I extended the trip and turned the business visit into something much closer to a holiday.

I travelled from Dubai to Melbourne and stayed at The Crown. Satinder Singh and Rodrigo Garcia, colleagues from work, were also there initially, but they were not really my travel companions. We did some sightseeing together while we were all in Melbourne, and after they left for India and the US, I continued on my own.

That change was significant. What had started as an official trip suddenly became personal travel, and Melbourne became a place I could experience without the structure of work around it.

A temple of cricket

One of the first places I wanted to see was the Melbourne Cricket Ground.

For an Indian, describing the MCG simply as a stadium does not really do it justice. Cricket in India is almost a religion, and some cricket grounds have the feeling of temples. The MCG felt like one of those temples to me.

Satinder, Rodrigo and I took a guided tour of the ground. We were shown around different parts of the stadium, including the dressing rooms and practice areas, and we also got the opportunity to go down to the cricket ground itself.

There is something different about seeing a place you have known for years through television and photographs and then suddenly finding yourself physically inside it. The MCG was not just another tourist attraction for me. It was a place that already had meaning before I ever arrived in Melbourne, because of what cricket represents back home.

We travelled around Melbourne using local public transport, which made getting around surprisingly easy. The city was accessible in a way that allowed us to move between places without needing a car or complicated arrangements.

We also visited the Rod Laver Arena. It was interesting to see another major sporting venue in the same city, but the MCG remained the place that stayed with me most strongly.

Soon afterwards, Satinder and Rodrigo left. One went back to India and the other to the United States.

And just like that, the official part of my trip and the company that came with it were over.

When the business trip became a holiday

After my colleagues left, Melbourne felt different.

There was no longer a seminar to attend, colleagues to meet or an office schedule to follow. I was now travelling for myself. I had extended the trip precisely for this reason, and the remaining days felt like a holiday.

At the same time, I did miss Pragati. If this had been planned as a personal holiday from the beginning, she could have joined me. So although I was enjoying the freedom of having the time to explore Australia, there was also the feeling that this was a holiday that could have been shared.

I decided to take a sightseeing tour along the Great Ocean Road.

The Great Ocean Road

I booked a group sightseeing tour in a small minivan. It was a full-day trip from Melbourne towards the Twelve Apostles, with stops along the way.

The journey itself was as memorable as the destination.

The landscape kept changing as we travelled away from Melbourne. The Great Ocean Road offered long stretches of coastline, dramatic views and a sense of space that was very different from the city. It was the kind of journey where the road becomes part of the attraction rather than simply something connecting two places.

One of the stops was Maits Rest Rainforest Walk. What I remember most from the rainforest were the huge trees, the dense natural surroundings and the colourful parrots and other birds. After the urban environment of Melbourne, being surrounded by that kind of nature was a completely different experience.

The contrast was part of what made the day interesting: a modern city at one end, and then a long journey through forests and along a spectacular coastline.

The Twelve Apostles

Eventually we reached the Twelve Apostles.

Seeing them in person was a multi-faceted experience. The first thing that struck me was the scale of these structures standing out in the ocean. They looked as though they had been placed there deliberately, but they were entirely natural formations, shaped over immense periods of time.

Then there was the ocean itself.

The wind in this part of Australia was remarkable. Standing on the southern coast and watching the waves and feeling the wind made it easy to understand that the landscape was not simply sitting there unchanged. Wind, waves and weather were still acting on the coast, just as they had done for countless generations.

That was perhaps the most interesting thought I carried away from the Twelve Apostles.

We tend to think of rocks and cliffs as permanent things. Human life is measured in years and decades, so something that has existed for thousands or millions of years feels almost eternal to us. But standing in front of the Twelve Apostles makes that idea difficult to hold on to.

These formations were created by the slow work of nature. The same forces that shaped the coastline were still working on it. Waves continued to strike the cliffs. Wind continued to move across the coast. Erosion continued, whether anyone standing there could see it happening or not.

What looked like monuments were actually temporary stages in a process that had been unfolding for an unimaginable length of time.

That is what makes geological landscapes so humbling. A human lifetime feels long when we are living it, but it is almost invisible against geological time. The Twelve Apostles made that contrast tangible for me. Nature does not need to hurry. It can spend enormous amounts of time sculpting a landscape, changing it grain by grain and wave by wave.

And eventually, even structures that appear immovable will change.

The Twelve Apostles were therefore more than beautiful rock formations to me. They were a reminder of scale — the scale of the ocean, the landscape, and especially the time over which the natural world operates.

Looking back

My Australia trip was never supposed to be a holiday.

It started with an office seminar that would have lasted only two days. I extended it because I had travelled so far and wanted to see something of Melbourne and the surrounding region. That simple decision changed the character of the journey completely.

With my colleagues, I experienced Melbourne through some of its most significant sporting landmarks, especially the MCG. After they left, I continued alone and took a day trip along the Great Ocean Road to the Twelve Apostles.

The trip gave me two very different kinds of memories. There was the excitement of standing inside the MCG, a place that carried enormous meaning for someone who had grown up with cricket in India. And there was the quiet perspective that came from standing on the southern Australian coast, watching waves and wind continue the

AUSTRALIA

work of shaping a landscape that had existed long before me and would continue changing long after I had gone.

I enjoyed those days after the official work was finished. It genuinely felt like a holiday.

But I also remember thinking that if Australia had been a personal trip from the beginning, Pragati would have been there with me.

Perhaps that is also part of what makes travel memorable. Sometimes a journey is carefully planned. Sometimes it appears because work sends you somewhere. And sometimes, if you are willing to extend the trip, an official journey quietly turns into an adventure of your own.

Part VI — India

Gujarat

Somnath



This was another of those trips that came together around an important date. My birthday was approaching, and as with New Year and other important calendar days, I liked the idea of spending it away from home. This time the destination was Somnath, because of the Jyotirlinga.

We flew from Delhi to Ahmedabad on 14 March 2014. The flight arrived around 6 in the evening, and there was very little time before our overnight sleeper bus to Somnath. The bus had been booked through RedBus; at that point we knew little more than the boarding point. We went straight there, had some food before boarding, and found ourselves waiting at what felt like a rather deserted spot, with just one shop and not many passengers around.

The sleeper bus made the overnight journey surprisingly easy. Most of the time was spent sleeping, and we reached Somnath early the next morning, around 7. It was a cold morning. We had not booked a hotel, so I asked the auto driver to take us around to a few places before we finally settled into Hotel Ambar.

Why Somnath

The main reason for coming to Somnath was, of course, the Somnath Jyotirlinga.

Somnath is one of the twelve Jyotirlinga shrines traditionally associated with Shiva, and the temple stands on the western coast of Gujarat near the Arabian Sea. The site has a long and complex history, with the temple having been destroyed and rebuilt several times. The present temple is part of a modern reconstruction that deliberately evokes the architectural traditions associated with the historic shrine.

I wasn't coming to Somnath to study that history. I was coming because I wanted to be there. But knowing a little about the place made standing in front of the temple feel different from simply visiting another temple on a sightseeing list.

We visited the temple in the evening and also visited a few local temples and places nearby. At one of the nearby temples we were able to do Rudrabhishekam, which was not allowed at Somnath itself.

Somnath itself felt beautifully calm. It was a full moon night, and there was something very peaceful about being there under that moon after the long journey from Delhi.

Bhalka Tirth and the story of Krishna

We also visited the spot associated with the belief that Lord Krishna left the earthly world after being struck by an arrow.

This is Bhalka Tirth, near Prabhas Patan. According to the traditional account, Krishna was mistaken for a deer by the hunter Jara and was

struck by an arrow; the episode is associated with Krishna's departure from earthly life.

For us, it was one of the smaller stops around Somnath rather than the main reason for the journey. But places like this add context to a pilgrimage. The region isn't defined by the Somnath temple alone; it is surrounded by sites connected to stories that have been part of Indian religious tradition for centuries.

When the trip went wrong

Unfortunately, the food did not suit Pragati and she fell sick.

By the time we were leaving Somnath, I was roaming around looking for a pharmacy to get medicines for her. It was Holi that day and most shops were closed. Luckily, I managed to find one that was open.

That small episode is one of those reminders that travel is never only about beautiful places. Sometimes the strongest memory is simply trying to solve a practical problem in an unfamiliar town.

On the night of 16 March we boarded the sleeper bus back to Ahmedabad. Again, it was an overnight journey and we reached Ahmedabad the next morning.

An unplanned Ahmedabad day

Since Pragati was still not feeling well, the pace was slow. I went out on my own to visit Adalaj Vav, something I had found by Googling at the last moment. It had not been part of the original plan, but it gave me some time to walk around and take photographs.

Adalaj Vav is a stepwell north of Ahmedabad, built in the fifteenth century. Stepwells were not simply water-storage structures; they were carefully designed spaces in which engineering, architecture and social life came together. Adalaj's descending levels, carved columns and changing light make it particularly memorable for photography.

I had discovered it almost by accident, and that made the visit even more enjoyable. There was no expectation attached to it. I simply found something interesting and went to see it.

We also visited Sabarmati Ashram, where I spent time going through the different places in the museum.

Sabarmati Ashram is closely associated with Mahatma Gandhi and his years in Ahmedabad. The site has become an important place for understanding the independence movement and Gandhi's philosophy. For me, the visit was less about ticking another famous Ahmedabad landmark and more about taking time to go through the exhibits and absorb the history.

Ahmedabad had now become more than just the place through which we were travelling because of the flights. It had become part of the birthday trip itself.

A very quiet birthday

My birthday was actually celebrated in Ahmedabad.

There wasn't much of a celebration — just a simple dinner at a restaurant in the Holiday Inn where we were staying. Pragati wasn't feeling like eating, so I went down alone for dinner.

While there, I noticed Parthiv Patel, the Indian wicketkeeper-batsman, also having dinner. I didn't want to disturb him while he was eating, so I waited until he had finished and then politely asked him for a selfie.

He obliged.

It was an unexpected little addition to a birthday that had otherwise been deliberately simple.

The next day, 18 March, we flew back to Delhi.

Looking back

GUJARAT

Somnath was never a long holiday. It was a short birthday journey built around a place of religious significance, and much of it happened through simple decisions made along the way.

There were two overnight sleeper-bus journeys, a full-moon evening at Somnath, the quiet of the temple, the story associated with Bhalka Tirth, Pragati falling sick, an emergency search for a pharmacy during Holi, an unplanned photographic visit to Adalaj Vav, Sabarmati Ashram and an unexpected meeting over dinner in Ahmedabad.

In the end, Ahmedabad became as much a part of the memory as Somnath itself.

That is something I have noticed repeatedly in our travels. The destination may be the reason you leave home, but the memories are often created by everything that happens around it.

Kashmir

Amarnath



The invitation

In July 2005, I was working in Haridwar when an email arrived from Giriraj, a colleague from Bangalore.

He was planning a trip to Amarnath and wanted to know if I would like to join him.

I knew very little about the Amarnath Yatra. Growing up in Tamil Nadu, the pilgrimages I was familiar with were places like Tirupati, Rameswaram and Kashi. Amarnath was somewhere in the Himalayas, associated with Shiva and an ice lingam. That was about as much as I knew.

But I have never been very good at saying no to travel.

Religion wasn't really the reason I said yes. Travel was.

I was 29, unmarried and working in Haridwar. The opportunity to travel into Kashmir and undertake my first Himalayan pilgrimage was enough.

Giriraj was coming from Bangalore. We decided to meet at Saharanpur.

I took a bus from Haridwar to Saharanpur and waited at the railway station for his train, the Shalimar Express. When he arrived, two colleagues from completely different parts of the country were suddenly travelling together.

Neither of us quite knew what we had signed up for.

Into Kashmir

The train journey was overnight. The coach was full of devotees heading towards the same destination. After spending the night sleeping on the train, we reached Jammu early in the morning.

From Jammu, our next challenge was getting to Pahalgam.

The buses were overflowing with pilgrims. There were simply too many people travelling towards the same place, and waiting for a regular bus did not seem like a sensible option.

The Tata Sumo became our solution.

We found a driver willing to take us to Pahalgam. Since the journey was going through Kashmir, Giriraj and I negotiated for the front seats. If we were going to spend hours travelling through the mountains, we wanted the view.

The journey took us through Anantnag towards Pahalgam.

By 2005, the Kashmir security situation was still very much a reality. We had heard about Army protection of the Amarnath Yatra, but hearing about it and experiencing it were two different things.

Near Anantnag, we reached an Army checkpoint.

The message was clear: civilian vehicles would not be allowed to continue that night. Pilgrims were to return to a transit camp and travel onward the following morning as part of the protected convoy.

The transit camp was a large FCI warehouse. Hundreds of pilgrims were already there, and there was hardly any space left.

Giriraj and I looked at the situation, then looked at our Tata Sumo.

The decision was easy.

We asked the driver whether we could sleep in the vehicle. He was initially concerned that the Army might inspect the vehicles during the night and question why passengers were sleeping inside. Eventually he agreed.

So that night, the Tata Sumo became our hotel.

It was late, we were tired, and somehow the five or six hours passed like two. I slept surprisingly well.

The next morning, the convoy moved towards Pahalgam, with Army vehicles at the front and rear and a long line of civilian vehicles carrying pilgrims in between.

For the first time, the scale of the operation became apparent. This wasn't simply a trek into the mountains. It was a pilgrimage involving thousands of people, moving through terrain where security had to be taken seriously.

Pahalgam and the trek

Pahalgam itself wasn't really a destination for us. It was the starting point.

There was chaos, crowds and the usual activity around the beginning of the Yatra. We didn't spend much time there before starting towards Amarnath.

And that's when we made our first mistake.

We carried our backpacks ourselves.

They hadn't seemed particularly heavy when we packed them. On a Himalayan trail, they suddenly seemed much heavier.

The route from Pahalgam to Amarnath was about 32 kilometres, with a night halt around Sangam.

For much of the journey, the trail was a narrow mountain path. Occasionally we crossed stretches of glacier, and the landscape changed dramatically as we climbed.

The ponies followed a different route for much of the way, usually slightly below the main trail. At places the two routes merged, and watching the ponies negotiate the narrow sections close to the valley was enough to convince me that I had no interest in riding one.

After several hours of walking, the backpack had become the real problem. I was exhausted. Hiring a pony started looking increasingly attractive.

Giriraj wasn't convinced.

We had come this far.

So we found a porter instead.

As it turned out, he was completing his own pilgrimage and was on his way back. He agreed to carry our backpacks.

Suddenly the trek became considerably easier.

Sometimes the smartest travel decision is simply knowing what weight you don't need to carry yourself.

We continued walking. There was no comfortable hotel waiting at the end and no leisurely evening planned before darshan. The destination was the cave itself.

The cave

When we finally reached Amarnath, the first surprise was the cave.

I had imagined something much smaller.

Instead, the cavern opened up into a huge natural space.

The queue for darshan was long, but it was moving, so the wait wasn't as difficult as I had expected.

And then came another surprise.

Photography was allowed inside the cave.

I had carried my camera all the way up, and now I could actually use it.

I photographed the cave and the ice lingam.

Standing there, looking at the naturally formed ice lingam, I felt more awe than anything else.

I had started this journey knowing very little about Amarnath. Now I was standing inside a massive Himalayan cave, surrounded by thousands of pilgrims, looking at something that had drawn people here for generations.

The physical journey had already changed the way I looked at the place.

Back through Baltal

The return route was very different.

The route through Baltal is only about 16 kilometres, considerably shorter than the 32-kilometre approach from Pahalgam, but it is steep.

The ascent and descent were demanding in their own way.

By then, however, we had already completed the longer route to the cave. The knowledge that the pilgrimage was essentially behind us made the return easier mentally, even when the trail itself wasn't.

Eventually we made our way back towards Srinagar.

One quiet night in Srinagar

After days of walking, crowds, mountains, security checkpoints and transit camps, Srinagar felt almost luxurious.

We stayed one night on a modest houseboat.

It wasn't particularly luxurious, but after the journey it didn't need to be.

We spent some time around Dal Lake and visited the Shankaracharya Temple overlooking the city.

It was a short pause before returning to ordinary life.

The next day we headed towards Jammu.

At the station, Giriraj and I went our separate ways.

He boarded his train towards Bangalore.

I boarded mine towards Haridwar.

Nine days after leaving, the journey was over.

What stayed with me

At 29, I didn't undertake Amarnath because I was searching for a religious experience. I went because a colleague asked me to join him, and because an opportunity to travel somewhere I had never been was difficult to refuse.

But the journey gave me something I carried forward.

A difficult trip is not necessarily an impossible trip.

The trek was hard. The backpack was a mistake. The cold water, the mountain paths, the distance and the altitude all tested us.

But once you decide that you are going to finish, you somehow keep moving.

TRAVELOGUE

That was probably the biggest thing Amarnath taught me about travel.

However tough a journey may be, determination can take you to the other side.

And perhaps that is why, even today, when I think back to my first Himalayan pilgrimage, I remember less about the difficulty and more about the feeling of finally standing inside that enormous cave.

At 29, I had simply said yes to a trip.

I didn't know then that it would become the beginning of many more journeys.

Ladakh

Leh – When the Mountains Became Real



Leh was not my first visit to Ladakh. I had been there once before, in April 2011, on a trip with my colleague and friend Manish. Eight years later, I returned with Pragati.

The two journeys could hardly have been more different. The first was an early-season adventure with a colleague, built around mountain roads and the excitement of discovering Ladakh for the first time. The second was a much more comfortable journey with Pragati, shaped by Army hospitality, better preparation and the experience of returning to a place I already knew.

Together, they tell a more complete story of my relationship with Ladakh.

April 2011 – The first Leh adventure

Manish and I had planned our Leh trip a year earlier, but had to cancel after the devastating 2010 cloudburst in Leh. A year later, we finally made the journey.

Our original idea was quite ambitious: we had considered renting bikes and riding all the way from Delhi. Eventually we decided to fly to Leh and rent bikes there instead.

We arrived in April, right at the beginning of the Leh season. Many of the attractions and mountain passes were still not open, so the bike plan was not practical for the main circuit. We decided to stay put initially, acclimatise and use the time to arrange the Inner Line Permits for Khardung La, Nubra and Pangong Tso.

Once the permits were in place, we hired a cab and planned a circuit from Leh to Khardung La, Nubra Valley and Hunder, returning to Leh before continuing towards Chang La and Pangong Tso.

There was one complication. Our original plan was to visit Pangong first, but the locals told us the lake was still frozen. We decided to reverse the itinerary and travel to Nubra first, hoping that Pangong would clear by the time we returned.

That small change captured something about the trip as a whole. We had travelled to Ladakh with an idea of what we wanted to do, but the mountains and the season dictated what was actually possible.

Khardung La and Nubra

Khardung La was my first experience of travelling at that altitude. I had a mild headache when we reached the pass. The Army personnel told me that it was normal and that it would disappear as we descended. Fortunately, that is exactly what happened.

From there we continued into Nubra Valley. We stopped at the large Maitreya Buddha statue and visited Diskit Monastery before reaching Hunder.

We found accommodation for the night in Hunder and went for a camel ride. The night itself became one of the unexpected highlights of the trip. There was almost no light pollution and the surroundings

were incredibly quiet. Looking up at the sky and seeing so many stars so clearly was something I still remember.

The next day we returned towards Leh, crossing Khardung La again.

There was another small but memorable detail about our stay. We had booked Hotel Tsokar in Leh for the entire duration of the trip. When we left Leh for the Nubra and Pangong excursions, we even left part of our luggage in the room. The hotel owners simply adjusted the booking and charged us only for the days we actually stayed there. That kind of flexibility was something we had never expected from a hotel in a city.

Pangong Tso

From Leh we headed towards Pangong Tso, now hoping that the lake had opened up enough for us to see it.

It had.

The excitement around Pangong was already high in those days, and the location had become even more popular after the movie *3 Idiots* showcased it. We took plenty of photographs.

The lake is said to stretch across India and China. We asked our driver to take us as far along the lake as he could. Even after travelling that distance, it felt like we had seen only a small fraction of the enormous lake.

On the return journey we passed Thiksey Monastery before heading back to Leh.

Once back in Leh, we finally rented a bike and explored locally, riding towards the Zaskar River and Shanti Stupa.

That first visit was short — just five days — but it introduced me to a landscape that would stay in my mind for years.

July 2022 — Returning to Leh

Nine years later, I returned to Leh with Pragati.

This time, she was coming with me.

Leh had been a distant dream for her. In her mind, it was almost an inaccessible place — somewhere far away in the mountains that required a great deal of effort to reach. I had a feeling that actually going there would change that perception.

It did.

We flew from Chennai to Delhi and then onwards to Leh.

The first two days were deliberately kept for acclimatisation. At high altitude, the best thing to do is often nothing at all. We took medication, slowed down and allowed ourselves time to get used to the altitude rather than immediately trying to conquer the place.

It worked. The altitude sickness I had built up in my own mind as something to be feared never really became a problem for either of us.

Our initial plan was to stay in a hotel in Leh. That changed when Pragati's college friend, who was serving in the Army, heard that we had booked accommodation. He immediately asked us not to worry about hotels and arranged Army guesthouse accommodation according to our route.

That changed the character of the trip completely.

We stayed in Army accommodation in Leh, Partapur and Tangtse. Because we were in our late forties and were staying around Army establishments, some of the soldiers assumed we were senior officials. They would salute us whenever they saw us.

It was extremely awkward.

We were simply guests, but explaining that to every person we met would have been even more awkward, so we quietly accepted the salutes and moved on.

The food was another pleasant surprise. Meals in the Army establishments were simple, home-like and exceptionally good. After a day of travelling in the mountains, sitting down to that food was something we genuinely looked forward to.

Khardung La and Nubra

Once we had acclimatised, our Innova became our transport for the entire circuit — Leh, Nubra, Thang, Pangong Tso and back to Leh.

Khardung La was our first major encounter with the high mountain roads.

The pass itself was far more crowded than I had expected. Bikers and tourists were everywhere, patiently taking turns to photograph themselves beside the famous Khardung La sign.

The altitude, however, did not trouble us. Two days of acclimatisation had done its job.

From there we continued towards Nubra Valley.

Hunder was one of the memorable stops. The double-humped Bactrian camels were something I had wanted to see again, and the landscape itself was striking. We also tried some of the go-karting-style rides in the valley, which added a lighter side to the journey.

The Maitreya Buddha statue in Nubra was another sight that stayed with us. Its scale and setting made it feel completely different from anything we had encountered elsewhere in the trip.

We continued towards Turtuk and then Thang, moving progressively closer to the border.

Thang and the last post

Thang is not a place one simply drives into as a tourist. Access requires Army permission.

Our Army friend had arranged the permissions for us, including a visit towards the last post.

The experience was unique.

At one point we could see Pakistani Army posts across the landscape.

There was something almost surreal about standing there looking towards another country's military positions and realising that while we were looking at them, they were quite possibly looking back at us.

Our driver was not particularly happy about going there. He appeared to prefer taking us to another tourist location from where we could have seen a similar landscape. But we had come specifically for this experience, and we stuck to the plan.

His irritation was evident for some time afterwards, until the journey eventually took us towards Pangong.

Pangong Tso

Pangong Tso was the highlight of the trip.

There are plenty of photographs of Pangong. They show the colours, the mountains and the enormous expanse of the lake. But photographs don't really explain what it feels like to stand there.

Its beauty is something that has to be experienced.

The landscape seemed almost unreal — the lake stretching out between the mountains, constantly changing character with the light and the sky.

After seeing it, I understood why people speak about Pangong with such fascination. Even having visited Leh before, this felt like a completely different experience because I was seeing it through Pragati's eyes as well.

Back to Leh

We returned to Leh after completing the circuit.

With the long-distance driving finished, we rented a Royal Enfield Meteor and spent the remaining time exploring around Leh together.

We rode towards Magnetic Hill, Gurudwara Pathar Sahib and the Sangam, enjoying the freedom of moving around at our own pace.

This part of the trip was different from the circuit in the Innova. The car had taken us across the major distances, but the motorcycle gave us the feeling of actually being on the road and in the landscape.

A different Leh for Pragati

For me, one of the most satisfying parts of this trip was seeing Pragati's perception of Leh change.

She had imagined Ladakh as an inaccessible, almost unreachable destination. After actually spending a week there, the mental barrier disappeared.

Leh was not inaccessible.

It was simply a place with a very different geography.

There were roads, hotels, tourists, bikers, markets and all the other things one associates with a tourist destination. But surrounding all of that was an extraordinary landscape that made Leh unique.

Two journeys, one place

The contrast between my two visits is what makes Ladakh particularly meaningful to me.

In 2011, I was discovering the place with Manish. We were dealing with the early-season conditions, changing plans because of frozen roads and lakes, arranging permits and figuring out how to make the journey work.

TRAVELOGUE

In 2022, I returned with Pragati. The journey was more comfortable, better prepared and helped by the extraordinary generosity of an Army friend. We had already learnt how important acclimatisation was, and we were able to travel deeper into Ladakh than we had on the first visit.

Yet some things remained unchanged: the scale of the mountains, the clear night sky, the feeling of distance and the sense that every road was taking us somewhere extraordinary.

My 2011 visit introduced me to Ladakh.

The 2022 journey made it special because I could experience it with Pragati.

And somewhere between the early-season mountain roads, the clear Hunder night sky, the Army guesthouses, the awkward salutes, the Royal Enfield ride and the vast blue expanse of Pangong Tso, the two journeys reminded me of something I have learned repeatedly through travel: sometimes a place becomes more memorable not because it is new to you, but because you return to it years later and see it through someone else's eyes.

Punjab

Amritsar



A sudden road trip

This was one of those journeys that happened almost without planning.

It was June 2007, just a short while after our marriage. Pragati and I decided to drive from Delhi to Amritsar in my Santro. There was no detailed itinerary, no hotel booked in advance and no real plan beyond getting to Amritsar and seeing what happened.

There was, however, one thing I was particular about.

Whenever I drive on a long road trip, I like to leave very early. And by early, I mean **very early** — around three or four in the morning.

The reason is simple: I would rather be on the road before the traffic wakes up.

So we left Delhi in the early hours and headed north.

At some point along the way, we had a flat tyre. It was an interruption, but not enough to change the plan. Once the tyre was fixed, we continued towards Amritsar.

We still had no idea where we would stay.

Finding a hotel

We reached Amritsar in the evening and started looking for somewhere to spend the night.

Eventually, we found a last-minute hotel near Sheranwala Gate. It was close enough to the Golden Temple for what we wanted to do, and since we had arrived without a reservation, finding a room at all felt like a small victory.

We parked the Santro at the hotel and decided to take a rickshaw towards the Golden Temple.

Cars weren't allowed close to the temple, so the rickshaw was the easiest way to get there.

And then we saw it.

The Golden Temple

The Golden Temple, or Harmandir Sahib, is the spiritual centre of Sikhism and one of India's most recognisable places of worship. The central shrine stands within the sacred sarovar, connected by a causeway, and the surrounding complex is designed around the water.

But knowing those facts doesn't prepare you for the first sight of it.

The complex was remarkably clean, calm and well organised despite the number of people moving through it. There was a long queue for entry, but it moved quickly, so we didn't have to wait very long.

What stayed with me most, though, was the view of the temple across the water.

The golden structure stood in the middle of the sarovar, and its reflection stretched across the surface of the water. It was one of those scenes that didn't need any explanation.

After visiting the temple, we spent some time sitting beside the sarovar.

There was nowhere we needed to rush to.

For a while, we simply sat there and enjoyed the view.

The experience also made the idea of the Golden Temple as a place of welcome more tangible. It wasn't just an architectural landmark we had come to photograph or see. It was a living place of worship, surrounded by people who had come for many different reasons.

Towards Wagah

The next day, we decided to go to the Wagah Border.

Wagah sits on the India–Pakistan border between Amritsar and Lahore. The daily Beating Retreat ceremony has become one of the best-known border spectacles in the region, with soldiers from the two sides carrying out highly choreographed drills before the flags are lowered. [\[?\]cite\[?\]turn0search16\[?\]](#)

It was late June and the weather was humid. There were occasional showers, and between the rain and the humidity, our clothes were regularly drenched in either rain or sweat.

On the way, we made a quick stop at Attari Railway Station.

It was mainly a photography stop — a few photographs, a short pause and then onward towards Wagah.

The closer we got to the border, the more people we saw heading in the same direction.

We drove as far as the parking area allowed, then left the car and walked quite a distance towards the border. There were crowds everywhere, with groups of people making the same walk towards the ceremony.

Eventually we found a comfortable place to sit.

Then the programme began.

The Wagah ceremony

The atmosphere at Wagah was completely different from the quietness of the Golden Temple.

There were patriotic songs, a large crowd and an unmistakable sense of excitement. Everyone was waiting for the flag ceremony.

When the ceremony began, the soldiers marched with the distinctive, almost theatrical precision that has become associated with Wagah. The flags were brought down, the ceremony unfolded and the crowd responded with enthusiasm.

It was fun to watch.

But there was also a genuine feeling of pride in being there and witnessing the ceremony at the border.

After it was over, we made our way back to the hotel.

Jallianwala Bagh

The following day, we visited Jallianwala Bagh.

After the crowds and energy of Wagah, the atmosphere here felt completely different.

Jallianwala Bagh is inseparable from one of the darkest episodes of India's freedom struggle. The massacre of 13 April 1919, when British troops fired on a gathering in the enclosed garden, left a deep mark on India's history and became a symbol of colonial repression.

Walking through the site and remembering what happened there makes the place difficult to experience simply as another tourist attraction.

After Wagah, where the crowd had been loud and celebratory, Jallianwala Bagh felt almost deliberately quiet. That contrast stayed with me.

We spent some time there before returning once again to Harmandir Sahib.

By then, the Golden Temple had become the place we wanted to return to rather than simply another item on our sightseeing list.

We had now spent three nights in Amritsar, and the trip had gradually acquired a rhythm of its own.

The unexpected stop in Ludhiana

Our original plan was straightforward: drive from Amritsar directly back to Delhi.

The weather had other ideas.

Heavy rain started during the return journey, and the driving speed dropped considerably. It soon became clear that continuing all the way to Delhi that night wasn't a sensible option.

So we changed the plan again.

We stopped in Ludhiana and found a hotel for the night.

Since Ludhiana is well known for its sweaters and jackets, the unplanned overnight stop also turned into an opportunity to do some

shopping. We picked up some warm clothes before settling in for the night.

The next day, we continued towards Delhi.

And just like that, the completely unplanned road trip was over.

What I remember

Looking back, what I like most about this journey is how little of it was planned.

We left Delhi at three or four in the morning because that was how I liked to drive. We had a flat tyre. We arrived in Amritsar without a hotel. We parked the car and took a rickshaw to the Golden Temple. We went to Wagah, stopped at Attari, visited Jallianwala Bagh and then ended up spending an unexpected night in Ludhiana because of the rain.

The places themselves also gave the trip a remarkable range. The Golden Temple offered stillness and reflection. Wagah brought spectacle and patriotic energy. Jallianwala Bagh brought history and sadness. And the road home reminded us, once again, that the weather can rewrite an itinerary in minutes.

Nothing went exactly according to a plan because there really wasn't one.

And perhaps that was the best part.

It was just Pragati and me, a Santro, a road heading north and the willingness to see where the journey took us.

Sometimes the trips that stay with you longest are the ones you never quite planned.

Rajasthan

Chasing Sunsets



My first major road trip

Rajasthan was my first major road trip, and that alone made it different from everything I had done before.

It was November 2004. I was living and working in Haridwar, and I had a relatively new car — a Santro I had bought only about six months earlier. Prasannaa travelled with me, and this was our opportunity to take the car out on a proper long-distance journey.

There was no great expedition plan behind it. We simply wanted to travel through Rajasthan, see the places we had heard about and discover what it was like to cover long distances by road.

What followed became one of those trips that stays in memory less because of a single event and more because of the road itself.

Setting out

We started from Haridwar and headed towards Delhi before entering Rajasthan.

The Santro was still relatively new to me, and this was the first time I was really putting it through the demands of a major road journey. On many days we covered more than 300 kilometres, and I did all the driving. Prasannaa had a driving licence, but on this trip the driving remained mine.

The route gradually unfolded through Jaipur, Bikaner and Deshnoke, then westwards towards Jaisalmer and Sam. From there we moved towards Jodhpur, travelling through Barmer, before returning via Jaipur and continuing on to Agra.

It was a lot of ground to cover in a relatively short journey.

But that was also the point of the trip. The journey between the destinations became as much a part of the experience as the destinations themselves.

There was a particular satisfaction in watching the landscape change as the kilometres accumulated. We had started in the north, moved through the major cities of Rajasthan, travelled deep into the desert region and then began the long journey back.

Jaipur and the road ahead

Jaipur was our introduction to Rajasthan on this journey.

From there, the trip quickly became a road trip in the true sense. We weren't staying in one place for long. Each destination was another stop on a much larger loop through the state.

Our accommodation was largely in RTDC hotels, which made the logistics fairly straightforward. After a long day on the road, having a known place to stop mattered more than luxury.

The rhythm became familiar: drive, arrive, explore, rest and then get back on the road.

At the time, long-distance road travel itself still felt like an adventure. There were no smartphones guiding every turn and no expectation that every hotel, restaurant or stop could be researched instantly. Much of the journey was simply about getting from one place to another and figuring things out along the way.

That made the Santro an important part of the experience. It wasn't just our transport. It was our constant companion through the journey.

Deshnoke

Deshnoke left one of the strongest impressions on me.

The place was unlike anything I had encountered before, and it was one of those stops that made the journey feel worthwhile even after hundreds of kilometres of driving.

What stayed with me was not simply the destination itself but the experience of arriving there and discovering something completely different from what I had imagined.

Travel often works that way. You may know a place by name before you visit, but the actual experience is rarely what you have pictured in your head.

Deshnoke was one of those places for me.

It also reinforced something that would become a recurring theme in my travels: some of the most memorable places are not necessarily the ones you spend the most time planning for.

Towards Jaisalmer

The further west we travelled, the more the character of Rajasthan changed.

Jaisalmer was another strong memory from the trip. The landscape, the sense of distance and the feeling of being deep inside the desert

region made it stand apart from the cities we had passed through earlier.

We continued towards Sam, where the desert experience became even more apparent.

By this stage, the Santro had become our constant companion. The car was only six months old when we started, and by now it had carried us across a substantial part of Rajasthan.

There is something special about a road trip in a relatively new car. Every unfamiliar road becomes part of the car's first major story, and this was certainly the case with the Santro.

The long stretches of road also changed the way I thought about distance. A place that looked close on a map could mean hours of driving. A destination wasn't simply somewhere we arrived at; the kilometres in between became part of the memory.

Jodhpur and the return journey

From the Jaisalmer side we continued towards Jodhpur, travelling through Barmer.

The distances were significant and the driving was demanding, but there was never a sense that we had to rush through the journey. The road itself was the experience.

Jodhpur became another stop before we turned back towards Jaipur.

By then, the trip had developed its own rhythm. We had become comfortable with long driving days and with the idea that the next destination was simply another part of the same journey.

From Jaipur we continued towards Agra.

The Taj Mahal was the final major stop of this journey, bringing the road trip to a natural close before we headed back towards the familiar surroundings of the north.

What the road taught me

Looking back, this was more than simply a trip to see Rajasthan.

It was my first major road trip and my first real opportunity to understand what travelling long distances by car could be like.

The Santro had been in my hands for only about six months. By the end of the journey it had travelled across a large part of Rajasthan, through cities, desert roads and long stretches where the destination sometimes felt very far away.

I also discovered something about myself as a driver. I enjoyed the long days on the road. Covering hundreds of kilometres wasn't simply a means of reaching the next place; there was something satisfying about watching the journey unfold through the windscreen.

Deshnoke and Jaisalmer remain the strongest destination memories from the trip, but the larger memory is of the road — the long drives, changing landscapes and the feeling of moving from one part of Rajasthan to another under our own steam.

The trip also reinforced something I would discover repeatedly in later travels: a journey does not have to be perfectly planned to become memorable. Sometimes the best part is simply being on the road and seeing where it takes you.

This was the beginning of my love for major road journeys.

And perhaps that is why I still remember this November trip as **Chasing Sunsets** — not because we were literally chasing every sunset, but because the road kept pulling us towards the next horizon.

Exact travel dates will be added when available.

Tamil Nadu

Kodaikanal



A birthday escape into the hills

Sometimes a journey is simply about getting away from the familiar.

For Pragati's birthday in August 2021, we decided to drive from our home in Chennai to Kodaikanal. Chennai's humid climate was reason enough to look for some relief in the hills, and Kodaikanal gave us exactly that.

Kodaikanal is one of Tamil Nadu's best-known hill stations, sitting high in the Palani Hills. Unlike a trip built around a long list of monuments, this was really about the change in atmosphere — leaving the heat of Chennai behind and spending a few days somewhere cooler and slower.

We drove our Hyundai Creta from Chennai and spent the trip at The Carlton Kodaikanal. The hotel is very nicely located right next to Kodaikanal Lake, making it easy to step out for a walk or spend some

time boating on the lake. We had booked a deluxe room for two with buffet breakfast and dinner and, apart from the accommodation, kept the trip deliberately simple.

Kodaikanal Lake

Kodaikanal Lake is one of the defining features of the town. The star-shaped lake sits in the middle of Kodaikanal and has long been part of the hill station's identity.

We visited the lake and spent time around the area, but the most enjoyable experience came from something much simpler than sightseeing.

The Carlton provided complimentary bicycles for its guests, and I decided to cycle around the lake.

The moment that stayed with me most was that ride. It was not something that required planning or a tourist checklist. It was just a beautiful way to experience Kodaikanal — cool air, the lake beside us and the hills around the town.

That became the highlight of Pragati's birthday trip.

A deliberately slow trip

We also visited a tea factory and the local market. There was no elaborate sightseeing itinerary.

That was intentional.

We had not come to Kodaikanal to see how many attractions we could fit into a weekend. The hills, the cooler weather and the slower pace were really what we had come for.

Kodaikanal has plenty of attractions that could easily fill a sightseeing schedule — viewpoints, waterfalls, forests and other mountain roads — but we were quite happy to let the town itself be the experience.

For Pragati's birthday, we kept the celebration equally simple — just a cake cutting at the hotel.

Sometimes the best birthday present is simply a change of scenery.

Back through Trichy

On the return journey we came through Trichy.

The route gave me an unexpected opportunity to revisit my engineering college. The college was empty, but I took some time to walk around, visit my old computer lab and simply refresh memories of my college years.

It was a very different kind of stop from the rest of the trip.

A few days earlier I had been cycling around a mountain lake with Pragati. Now I was walking through the place where an earlier version of my life had taken shape, looking at an old computer lab and remembering my engineering years.

The contrast made the return journey more meaningful than a simple drive home.

Looking back

Kodaikanal was therefore a quiet birthday getaway rather than a sightseeing-heavy holiday.

A drive from Chennai, cool mountain weather, a comfortable stay beside the lake, a simple birthday celebration, cycling around the lake and, on the way home, an unexpected visit back to my engineering college.

There was no dramatic adventure and no long list of famous places.

But perhaps that is precisely why I remember it fondly.

TAMIL NADU

Some journeys are about discovering somewhere completely new.
Others are about slowing down with someone you love, celebrating a small occasion and enjoying a few days away from the routine.

Kodaikanal was one of those trips.

Uttar Pradesh

Spiritual Varanasi



Varanasi has stayed with me for a reason that is difficult to explain. I have been there twice, eight years apart, and the two journeys could hardly have been more different. The first was a photography trip with my mentor and a group of photographers. The second was with Pragati and was much more spiritual and personal. Yet both journeys brought me back to the same ghats, the same river and the same extraordinary energy of Varanasi.

November 2017 — Through a photographer's eyes

In November 2017, I flew from Sharjah to Varanasi with a group of roughly fifteen photographers from the FSO (Friday Shoot Out) group in Dubai. The tour was organised by my mentor, **Lal Nallath**, with the intention of photographing Varanasi around Dev Deepawali.

Dev Deepawali is observed on Kartik Purnima, the full moon that follows Deepawali. The celebrations around Varanasi run for weeks, and the ghats become an extraordinary canvas of lamps, people and

colour. For us, it was an opportunity to photograph the city and, more importantly, to learn from Lal.

We flew directly into Varanasi and then made our way towards the hotel. The last stretch was through narrow lanes that could not accommodate cars. With fifteen people and a lot of luggage, we had to use several cycle rickshaws, two or three people to a rickshaw, with the luggage distributed between them. The hotel itself was a small, decent place close enough to the ghats to walk.

Most of the trip was spent with cameras in hand. We visited the ghats for the Ganga Aarti and for the evening celebrations when the lamps illuminated the riverfront. We visited a traditional akhada, where wrestlers trained and fought, and spent time in a weavers' colony photographing the craftsmen at work. We also visited Sarnath and its Buddhist temple.

One morning we planned to photograph the sunrise first and then go to the akhada. We were running late and rushed there in a few auto-rickshaws. In the excitement of getting there before the sunrise, I put my tripod in the back of the auto and completely forgot about it when I got down. By the time I realised, the auto was long gone. It remains one of those small, painful memories that become part of a trip's story.

Although the journey was primarily about photography, Lal had encouraged me to experience Varanasi beyond the camera. I managed to find some time on my own to take a dip in the Ganges and visit the Kashi Vishwanath Temple.

This was before the Kashi Corridor was created. The approach to the temple was through incredibly narrow lanes, crowded with devotees. Even a two-wheeler would have struggled to get through. The temple entrance itself felt quite ordinary — in through one place, out through another — and after leaving my footwear behind, I actually found myself struggling to remember where I had entered.

Of all the photographs I took on that trip, the candid images of pilgrims taking a dip in the Ganges remain among my favourites. There was something surreal about watching these moments unfold naturally, without anyone performing for the camera.

There was plenty of street food too, and between the food, the river, the lamps and the photography, the trip became an intense lesson in seeing. I had gone to Varanasi to learn photography. I came back with photographs, memories and a small glimpse of something much deeper.

November 2025 — Varanasi with Pragati

Eight years later, Varanasi happened almost by accident.

Pragati and I were in Agra visiting her father. We had originally considered taking a cab all the way to Varanasi, but that seemed too tiring. A newly started Vande Bharat service gave us another option, and we decided to take the train instead.

My experience from 2017 influenced one decision immediately: this time, we would stay as close to the ghats as possible. I wanted the river to be within easy reach, and being close to the Ganga Aarti and the temple would make everything easier.

We arrived in Varanasi in the evening and travelled towards the ghats by cab and rickshaw. The final stretch had to be walked with our luggage because the hotel was completely inaccessible to vehicles. I struggled with the luggage and only later realised that we could have called the hotel and someone would have come to carry it for us.

The hotel was **Dwivedi Hotels Palace On Steps**, right on the banks of the Ganges. Our Trishul room had a river view. The moment I saw the Ganges from the room, all the tiredness of the journey disappeared. This is something I have always loved when travelling — the feeling that the view from a room can make the entire effort of getting there worthwhile.

This visit covered many of the places I had seen in 2017, including the ghats, the Ganga Aarti and Sarnath, but the company changed the nature of the journey completely. This time I was with Pragati, and the trip felt much more spiritual than photographic.

Pragati had specifically told me not to miss taking a dip in the Ganges and visiting Kashi Vishwanath. So I did both. The Kashi Corridor was now in place, a dramatic change from what I remembered in 2017. We struggled to find the VIP entrance, but eventually managed to get the darshan.

And then there was Pragati's Varanasi experience — shopping.

She discovered the Banaras handwoven dress materials and, quite literally, ran around like a kid in a toy store. Watching her excitement became one of the highlights of the trip. Varanasi was giving us two very different experiences: for me, the river and the temples; for her, the handlooms and the shopping; and for both of us, the atmosphere of the city.

We also moved to a second hotel for the last part of the stay. **Saffron**, near the main junction close to the temple, made the final leg convenient.

I was not in particularly good shape during this trip. Normally it is Pragati who tends to fall sick while travelling, but this time it was my turn. I developed a bad throat infection and flu-like symptoms during the last two days. I somehow continued with the sightseeing. Perhaps it was the environment, perhaps the dip in the Ganges, perhaps something I ate — I never figured out what caused it.

The return journey gave us another story that we are unlikely to forget.

On the day of departure, we were already late returning from Sarnath. We rushed back to the hotel, collected our luggage and took the auto-

rickshaw arranged by the hotel towards the railway station. There was just one problem: nobody had clarified **which** railway station.

Varanasi has several railway stations, and by the time we reached ours, we realised we were at the wrong one. We had only about thirty minutes left before the train.

Seeing our troubled faces, an auto driver understood what had happened. He promised he could get us to the correct station in time — and then somehow did exactly that. It was one of those moments during travel when a complete stranger steps in, understands the urgency and simply gets on with helping you. We made it.

Two visits, one Varanasi

Looking back, the two trips feel almost like two different cities.

In 2017, I was looking through a camera. I was learning from Lal, chasing light, photographing pilgrims, wrestlers, weavers and the lamps along the ghats. The spiritual experience came almost incidentally, in the quiet moments when I stepped away from the group.

In 2025, I was travelling with Pragati. The camera was no longer the centre of the journey. The Ganges, the temple, the darshan and the simple act of being there mattered more. The city had changed too — most visibly in the Kashi Corridor — but the essential character of Varanasi felt remarkably familiar.

Perhaps that is what makes Varanasi special. You can return years later with a different person, a different purpose and a different life behind you, and somehow the river is still there waiting for you.

West Bengal

Darjeeling



Let's get away for New Year

I like to spend important calendar days away from home — birthdays, anniversaries, New Year and days like that. So when we decided, almost at the last minute, that we should get away for New Year, Darjeeling seemed like the perfect place.

Neither Pragati nor I had been to Darjeeling before. The idea of going to the mountains in winter had its own thrill.

The decision was made only a few days before the trip. We booked the flights on 27 December for a journey starting on 30 December.

This time, however, the suddenness of the trip did not mean we could leave everything until we arrived. We needed a taxi from Bagdogra to

Darjeeling, and we needed somewhere for the driver to take us. So we booked the hotel in advance as well.

We were staying at Cedar Inn.

Delhi to Bagdogra

Our flight was around midday, but travelling out of Delhi at the end of December came with its own uncertainty.

It was foggy. Flights were being cancelled, and suddenly our spontaneous New Year plan didn't feel quite so simple.

The worry was not just about the flight.

Our hotel booking was prepaid. If the flight was cancelled, we would not only lose the trip but potentially lose the money we had already paid for the stay as well.

So the wait at Delhi airport was tense.

Eventually, we were on our way.

At Bagdogra, there was a pleasant surprise waiting for us. A brand-new Baleno was waiting with the driver, who was standing there with a placard carrying our names.

Everything had worked out.

The road to Darjeeling

The drive from Bagdogra to Darjeeling was more than just a transfer. The landscape changed steadily as we climbed away from the plains, the roads became more mountainous and the cold became increasingly noticeable.

Darjeeling sits high in the Himalayan foothills, surrounded by tea gardens, forests and views towards the great peaks of the eastern Himalayas. It is easy to understand why the town acquired its reputation as the Queen of the Hills.

We had come looking for winter in the mountains, and Darjeeling was not disappointing us.

By the time we reached the hotel, it was almost dark.

Cedar Inn itself was wonderful. Our room had a coal chimney that served as the heater, and the view from the bedroom was something we had not expected — Kanchenjunga in all its majesty.

Kanchenjunga is the world's third-highest mountain, and seeing it from the comfort of our room made the long journey from Delhi feel worthwhile almost immediately.

We retired to the room to wear away the tiredness of the journey.

Actually, saying we were tired isn't quite right.

Mountains only refresh; they never tire anyone.

Darjeeling

The next few days were spent exploring Darjeeling and its surroundings. We used the same driver who had brought us from Bagdogra to take us around.

We visited the Kanchenjunga viewpoint. In a way, it was hardly necessary because we already had a magnificent view of Kanchenjunga from our bedroom every day.

But we were tourists, after all. Sometimes you have to do the touristy things.

We also went to Simana, near the Nepal border, and visited the local zoo. St. Paul's School was right across from our hotel, so we went there as well.

The town itself had the character of a classic hill station — steep roads, old buildings, mountain views and the constant presence of the surrounding hills. Even ordinary drives felt different from travelling in the plains.

And then there was the toy train

Darjeeling and the toy train are almost inseparable in the imagination of anyone visiting the place.

The Darjeeling Himalayan Railway is not simply a tourist attraction. It is a remarkable piece of mountain railway engineering. The narrow-gauge line was built in the late nineteenth century to connect the plains with Darjeeling, climbing dramatically through the Himalayan foothills. UNESCO later recognised it as part of the Mountain Railways of India World Heritage Site. [?]cite[?]turn0search2[?]turn0search4[?]

The railway uses tight curves, zigzags and loops to gain altitude, with Ghum — high in the hills — forming one of its most famous points. The Batasia Loop is particularly well known for the way the railway negotiates the steep terrain while opening up views of the mountains. [?]cite[?]turn0search12[?]

We couldn't get a ticket, but we did see the train at the station and several times along the route.

That became one of the unfinished items on this trip.

In a way, knowing what the railway represented made missing the ride even more frustrating. We had come all the way to Darjeeling and had seen the famous little train, but had not actually experienced the journey it was built for.

One day, whenever we return to Darjeeling, we would like to actually ride it.

New Year in the mountains

We spent New Year's Eve at the hotel.

There was no need for a big celebration or a crowded party. We were in the mountains, it was cold outside, and our room had a coal chimney keeping us warm.

So we simply chilled, enjoyed the weather and welcomed the New Year in our own way.

For me, that was exactly what I had wanted when we decided to get away for New Year in the first place.

There was something particularly satisfying about ending one year and starting another in a place so different from everyday life in Delhi. We had not planned an elaborate celebration. We had simply changed the surroundings, and that was enough.

A trip that felt unfinished

Darjeeling gave us what we had gone looking for — mountains, winter, cold weather and a break from home.

But the trip also left us with a couple of reasons to return.

We hadn't been able to ride the toy train. And having come all the way to this part of the country, we hadn't made it to Gangtok either.

So the journey felt slightly incomplete.

Perhaps that is not such a bad thing.

Some places are better when they leave something unfinished.

Darjeeling is one of those places for us.

There is still a toy train to ride, and there is still Gangtok waiting for a future visit.

Which means a second trip to Darjeeling is already on the list — someday.

Epilogue

A journey rarely ends when we return home.

The places may become photographs, the tickets may disappear into drawers, and the details may slowly fade. But some journeys remain with us in ways that are difficult to explain. A road, a conversation, a meal, a missed turn, a sudden snowfall, a quiet morning, or an unexpected moment can stay in memory for years.

Looking back across these travels, what I remember most is not a list of destinations. It is the accumulation of moments — the people who travelled with me, the colleagues who helped along the way, the plans that changed, and the small surprises that made each journey its own story.

Perhaps that is why I kept travelling, and why I kept photographing.

Travel gave me a way to look at the world, but returning home gave me a way to understand what those journeys meant.

These stories are my attempt to bring a little of that world home.

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About the Author

V.T.R. Ravi Kumar is the author of *Engineering Home: Rediscovering the Engineer Beyond the Workplace*, *Gen Z: Generation Zero*, and *The White Envelope*.

He writes across engineering, society, memory, and personal experience, with a continuing interest in documenting the journeys and stories that shape how we see the world.

Ravi lives in Chennai with his wife, Pragati, where he continues to write, build software, explore new technologies and pursue a lifelong curiosity about how stories and engineering can together create something meaningful.

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More from V.T.R. Ravi Kumar

This travelogue is one part of a continuing journey of writing, engineering, exploration and discovery.

Engineering Home: Rediscovering the Engineer Beyond the Workplace An engineering memoir about rediscovering the engineer within after leaving the traditional workplace — through curiosity, experimentation, failure and the enduring mindset of an engineer.

Gen Z: Generation Zero A story about AI, identity, time and human agency — and what happens when an intelligence grows alongside a human being.

The White Envelope A personal story of choices, uncertainty, relationships and the moments that can quietly change the course of a life.

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TRAVELOGUE

Thank you for reading my travelogue.

If these pages reminded you of your own journey, then this memoir has accomplished its purpose.

— **V.T.R. Ravi Kumar**

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